



CITY: Pg 2

Six-yr-old boy drowns in pit; Gr Noida Authority sacks 2 officials



NATION: Pg 5

'Did you approve use of lethal force, pellet guns?' Rahul asks Shah



FILM: Pg 12

The face behind NEET protest's viral image

CENTRE TO ADOPT RECOMMENDATIONS FOR LEAKPROOF, TRANSPARENT EXAMS

Aadhaar architect Nilekani to head govt's task force on exam reforms

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major move aimed at restoring confidence in India's public examination system, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced the formation of a high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to recommend reforms that would make examinations secure, transparent and resistant to paper leaks. The announcement came a day after the Centre accepted key demands of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), including the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, bringing an end to a 36-day nationwide protest over the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak and other examination-related issues.

In a video message posted on Instagram, Modi said the government had been taking continuous steps to protect students' interests and would implement the panel's recommendations as soon as its report is submitted.

"For the future of students, the Government of India has been continuously taking different steps," the Prime Minister said. Referring to those accused in paper leak cases, he added that those "who played with the future of the students" had been jailed and announced that the Centre would introduce a new law in Parliament on Monday to deal more firmly with examination paper leaks.

"But we will have to think about the future. To make sure our examination system is trustworthy, transparent



KEY POINTS

- » Government will implement task force recommendations after receiving its report
- » Nilekani says committee will focus on comprehensive NTA examination reforms



- » Panel includes S. Somanath, Tapan Deka, V. Kamakoti, Anita Karwal and Amrit Lal Meena
- » Modi says paper leak accused have been jailed
- » Centre to introduce stronger anti-paper leak bill in Lok Sabha Monday

and the technology is used optimally, we have decided to constitute a high-powered committee headed by world renowned technology expert Nandan Nilekani," Modi said.

He said the task force had been created to recommend comprehensive examination reforms and assured students that the government would

quickly implement its suggestions to strengthen the credibility of future examinations.

The multidisciplinary panel will recommend reforms for examinations conducted by the National Testing Agency (NTA). Besides Nilekani, the committee includes former ISRO chairman S. Somanath, former

'NEW SUBJECT FOR ME': PRALHAD JOSHI TAKES CHARGE AS EDUCATION MINISTER

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Union Minister Pralhad Joshi on Sunday assumed charge as the Union education minister, a day after President Droupadi Murmu accepted the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan and assigned him the additional responsibility of the ministry. Joshi will continue to handle his existing portfolios while overseeing the Education Ministry. The change came after Pradhan stepped down on Saturday amid nationwide student protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party over the NEET paper leak controversy.

After taking charge, Joshi said he had begun reviewing the ministry's work and meeting senior officials to understand its functioning before making policy decisions.

"The Prime Minister has entrusted me with this responsibility with full confidence. This is a new subject for me. I have taken charge today

Continued on P4

SWIMMERS REACH RELAY FINAL

Mirabai dazzles with record lift, Rishikanta earns silver



S KANNAN

GLASGOW: Olympic medalist Mirabai Chanu delivered another commanding performance to win a record third consecutive Commonwealth Games gold on Sunday, while Rishikanta Singh battled a knee injury to clinch a historic silver as India enjoyed a strong day in weightlifting.

Competing in the women's 48kg category, Mirabai rewrote the Commonwealth and Commonwealth Games record books with a total lift of 190kg, including 85kg in snatch and 105kg in clean and jerk. The 31-year-old from Manipur recovered after missing her opening attempts in both disciplines and still fin-

ished a massive 22kg ahead of Nigeria's Ruth Asuquo Nyong, who settled for silver with 168kg. With the title secured and the Asian Games less than two months away, Mirabai skipped her final clean and jerk attempt. The victory gave India its first gold and third medal of the Games after para powerlifter Jhandu Kumar's heavyweight bronze on Friday.

Earlier, Rishikanta raised hopes of gold by equalling the Commonwealth Games snatch record with 121kg to lead after the opening discipline. However, a knee injury suffered a week before the competition resurfaced during the clean and jerk, restricting him to 143kg and a total of 264kg. Malaysia's Mohamad



Aniq Kasdan surged to gold with a Games record total of 273kg, while Kenya's Joshua Amunga Mboya took bronze with 260kg.

India also stayed in medal contention in swimming as the men's 4x200m freestyle relay team of Dhakshan Shashikumar, Aneesh Sunil Kumar Gowda, Aryan Nehra and Srihari Nataraj clocked 7:39.48 to qualify fifth overall for the final after edging Jersey.

In lawn bowls, Rupa Rani Tirkey and Pinki Singh's three-match winning run ended with a tie-break defeat to Namibia's Amanda Steenkamp and Diana Viljoen. The Indian pair must now beat England in their final sectional match to keep their semifinal hopes alive. See P11

Quick News

SIDDARAMAIAH RULES OUT CONTESTING 2028 KARNATAKA POLLS

BENGALURU: Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, 79, said he will not contest the 2028 Assembly elections, citing age and "deeply polluted" politics. The Congress leader said he will remain active in public life and speak for people's welfare. He said he expects to be 81 or 82 by the next polls. See P5

TEJ PRATAP SENT TO 14-DAY JUDICIAL CUSTODY

PATNA: Janshakthi Janta Dal chief Tej Pratap Yadav was sent to 14 days of judicial custody after a Patna court heard his case shortly after midnight. The son of RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav was detained during Bihar Bandh protests over the NEET paper leak. See P5

Opposition to corner Centre in Parl on 'police brutality' against students, insist on PM's apology

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress-led opposition is preparing to intensify its attack on the government in Parliament over the alleged police action against students protesting the NEET paper leak, with demands for accountability, action against those responsible and an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

According to opposition sources, the INDIA bloc will meet in the chamber of Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge on Monday morning to finalise its floor strategy. The meeting is also expected to decide the alliance's stand on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, which is scheduled to be introduced in the Lok Sabha the same day.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi has written to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, seeking accountability for what he described as a "bar-



HIGHLIGHTS

- » INDIA bloc to finalise floor strategy at Monday morning meeting
- » Alliance will decide its

- stand on anti-paper leak amendment bill
- » Rahul Gandhi writes to Amit Shah seeking accountability for alleged student assault

baric assault" on students who were protesting peacefully. In the letter, Gandhi questioned whether Shah had approved the use of "lethal force", including pellet guns, during the demonstrations.

Calling peaceful protest a vital part of democracy, Gandhi said it was the government's responsibility to protect demonstrators and address their concerns through dialogue. "Such brutal violence

destroys every norm, and has outraged the country. Youth and students, the future of our country, are demanding answers and accountability. Their voice will be heard," he wrote.

Sharing the letter, Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said Gandhi had asked Shah two questions: whether he had authorised the use of pellet guns and other force against

Continued on P4

No law against eating chicken on Ganga, protesting for Gaza: SC judge

MPOST BUREAU

BHOPAL: Supreme Court Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Saturday voiced concern over what he described as the shrinking space for dissent in India, questioning arrests over peaceful activities, restrictive bail conditions, and judicial approaches that could discourage citizens from exercising their constitutional freedoms. Speaking at the Justice GP Singh 4th Memorial Lecture at the National Law Institute University (NLIU) in Bhopal, Justice Bhuyan said courts have a responsibility to protect the rights of citizens and called for greater introspection within the judiciary to retain public trust.

Referring to recent instances involving criminal action against people exercising their right

Continued on P4

TAKEAWAYS

- » Protest site deserted; tents dismantled, volunteers gone after month-long NEET-UG 2026 agitation
- » CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke recovering at home after typhoid diagnosis
- » Sonam Wangchuk, who joined via hunger strike, still recovering at Medanta Hospital

While the protest concluded on a triumphant note, its leaders spent Sunday recovering from weeks of physical and emotional strain.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, who has been

Continued on P4



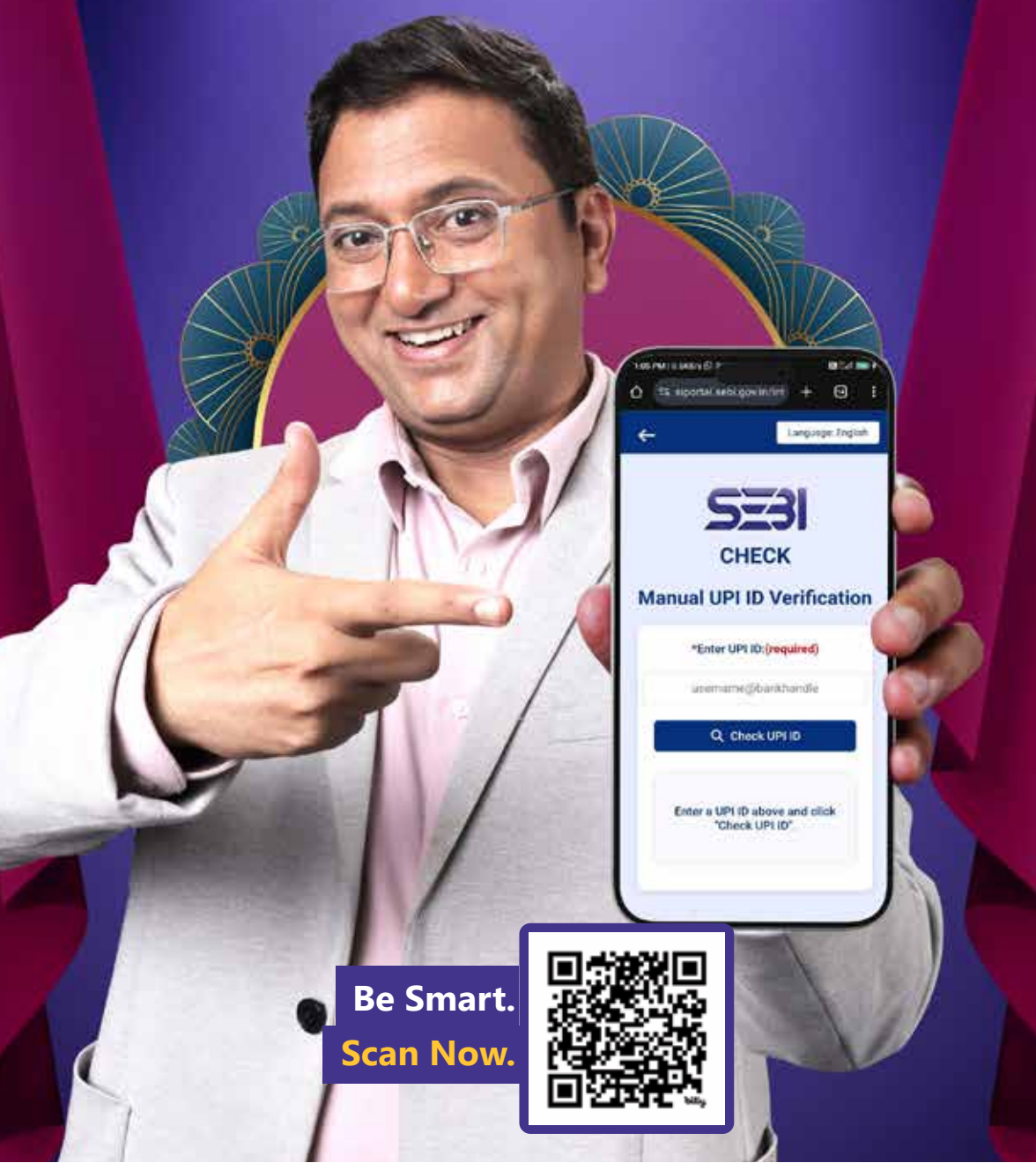
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Six-yr-old boy drowns in pit; Gr Noida Authority sacks 2 officials

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: The Greater Noida Authority on Sunday dismissed two officials, blacklisted a contractor and ordered criminal action after a six-year-old boy drowned in a water-filled pit dug for a tube-well project in Knowledge Park II. A departmental inquiry has also been initiated into the incident.

The victim, Avvaan Surya, son of Sivan Yadav, died on Saturday evening after falling into the excavation near Kaladham Society. According to residents, the child was playing with other children at around 7 pm when he entered the pit to retrieve a stick. He allegedly slipped into the water-filled excavation and could not be rescued in time. He was taken to Yatharth Hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

The incident triggered protests by residents, who alleged that the excavation had been left uncovered and without barricades or warning signs despite posing a serious safety risk.

Greater Noida Authority CEO Ravi Kumar NG said a preliminary inquiry found that the contractor had begun the tubewell work without putting mandatory safety measures in place. "The contractor has been blacklisted and directions have been issued to register an FIR against him. No con-



Excavation for the tubewell had started 3 days ago. The contractor began work without informing senior officers

struction work can be carried out without ensuring proper safety arrangements," he said. The inquiry also found lapses within the Authority's Water Department. "Technical Supervisor Akash Kumar and Supervisor Johnny Kumar have been dismissed from service for negligence and failure to discharge their responsibilities. A departmental inquiry has also been ordered to fix accountability," Ravi Kumar said.

The probe will be conducted by General Manager (Projects) A.K. Singh. Follow-

Two die inside Noida STP during cleaning

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: A 22-year-old security guard died while attempting to rescue a sanitation worker who had fallen unconscious inside a sewage treatment plant (STP) at Eldeco society in Sector 150 early on Sunday, raising serious concerns over safety practices during confined-space cleaning operations.

The deceased were identified as Akash Singh (22), a resident of Firozabad, and Shashikant Sharma (40), a contractor from Rajasthan. Police said the incident occurred at around 3 am when Shashikant entered the STP tank to clean it. After he

failed to respond to repeated calls, Akash covered his face with a handkerchief and climbed into the tank to rescue him, but was also overcome by toxic gases.

The fire department received a call at around 4 am and rushed to the society. Chief Fire Officer Pradeep Kumar Choubey said rescuers equipped with breathing apparatus entered the nearly 40x40-ft STP, which contained no water but was filled with poisonous gases, including methane and carbon dioxide.

"It took around 50 minutes and nearly 15 fire personnel to pull out both victims. One officer entered

the tank twice to locate them. The security guard was found first, while the second victim was recovered deeper inside the chamber," Choubey said.

Both men were taken to a nearby hospital. Police said Shashikant was declared dead on arrival, while Akash succumbed to his injuries during treatment.

Preliminary investigation found the society had outsourced STP cleaning to a private firm. Police registered an FIR against the builder, maintenance head and security head, and are investigating whether mandatory safety equipment was provided before workers entered the confined space.

Hawker dies after assault near AIIMS Metro station

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 49-year-old street vendor was allegedly strangled to death with a belt after a minor altercation near the AIIMS Metro station in south Delhi, with the accused being overpowered by bystanders and handed over to police, an official said on Sunday.

The victim, Manoj Singh, a native of Mai village in Bihar's Nawada, had been selling clothes on a pavement outside Gate No. 3 of Safdarjung Hospital for around two decades. He died during treatment at Safdarjung Hospital after the attack, police said.

The accused, identified as Lokesh (40), a resident of Taimur Nagar, was arrested on the spot after passersby caught him and informed police.

The incident took place on the night of July 23 near Gate No. 3 of the AIIMS Metro station on Aurobindo Marg.

According to the police, a PCR call reporting a quarrel was received at Hauz Khas



police station, following which a police team rushed to the spot and shifted the injured Singh to Safdarjung Hospital. He later succumbed to his injuries.

A case of murder has been registered at Hauz Khas police station, and further investigation is underway.

Police said preliminary investigation revealed that the incident stemmed from a minor verbal altercation at a nearby bus stand, which escalated into a physical fight.

Bitu Kumar, the deceased's son, said his father had been working as a street vendor selling clothes outside Safdarjung Hospital for nearly 20 years.

"At around 10 pm, my father was returning home after

The accused, Lokesh (40), a resident of Taimur Nagar, was arrested on the spot after passersby caught him: Police

wrapping up the day's work. An intoxicated man deliberately bumped into him near the metro station and started picking a fight. My father tried to avoid the confrontation and walked away, but the man followed him, removed his belt and strangled him from behind," Bitu alleged.

He said people present at the spot caught the accused and handed him over to police, while his father, who had fallen unconscious, was taken to the hospital.

"We got to know about the incident around 11 pm that night. My father had been earning his livelihood by selling clothes on the roadside for the last 20 years," he said.

Three held for cab driver's murder

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have solved the murder of a cab driver in Krishna Nagar, arresting two men and apprehending a juvenile, while a fourth accused remains absconding.

Police said Vijay Kumar (40), a resident of West Vinod Nagar, was found with multiple stab wounds inside his cab on July 23 and was declared dead at Dr Hedgewar Hospital.

Investigation revealed that the four accused allegedly consumed liquor before planning to rob a cab driver. Aman allegedly procured a knife and booked a Rapido cab using Ayan's

mobile phone. The group allegedly stabbed Kumar near Chitra Vihar crossing, placed him in the back seat and fled with the vehicle, later abandoning it near East Azad Nagar Metro Station after being chased by the public.

Police identified the accused through CCTV footage, call records and technical evidence. Ayan (20), Sahil (19) and a juvenile were apprehended, while Aman remains at large. The murder weapon, blood-stained car, clothes and mobile phones were recovered. Further investigation is underway.

MPOST

News at a glance

COURT UPHOLDS FOUR-YEAR SENTENCE TO MAN

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court upheld the four-year rigorous imprisonment of a man convicted under the Arms Act for possessing an illegal country-made pistol, rejecting his appeal. Citing his extensive criminal record, the court said his repeated offending outweighed claims of false implication, family hardship and reformation in custody.

DEFENCE 'SHIFT-ED LIKE A RIVER'

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court upheld a woman's conviction in a cheque bounce case, observing that her defence "shifted like a river" from denial to claims of repayment. Upholding the Rs 5 lakh compensation, the court said her contradictory stand failed to rebut the legal presumption under the Negotiable Instruments Act.

FAMILY AWARDED RS 16.73 LAKH FOR ROAD DEATH

NEW DELHI: A Delhi Motor Accident Claims Tribunal awarded Rs 16.73 lakh compensation to the family of a 45-year-old fruit seller who died after an SUV hit him in Uttar Pradesh's Baghpat district in 2017. Holding the driver negligent, the tribunal directed National Insurance Company Ltd to pay the compensation with 7.5 per cent annual interest. It rejected the insurer's objection over the 81-day delay in registering the FIR.

'Sleeping on pavement does not contribute to negligence'

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court has enhanced the compensation awarded to the victims and the kin of the deceased in a road accident, stating that sleeping on pavements cannot be held to be an act contributing to the negligence of the offending truck driver.

Justice Anish Dayal set aside the decision of the Motor Accidents Claims Tribunal (MACT), which reduced the compensation payable to the families of two deceased persons and two surviving victims by half, and said the finding



attributing 50 per cent "contributory negligence" to the claimants was unsustainable.

The judge said a pedestrian using a pavement for walking, standing, or resting owing to compelling circumstances cannot be expected to anticipate that a motor vehicle would be driven onto the footpath and a

'...certainly cannot be used for driving': HC

driver ought to be more cautious while driving in an area meant for pedestrians.

"It is a reality in this country that many persons are homeless, work through the night, or are part of labour deployed at various construction sites and do not have a place to sleep. For such persons, these pavements

also become a relatively safer place to rest, considering that they do not expect vehicles to be driven onto the pavements and mow them down. Even if they had taken a calculated risk sleeping on the pavement, it certainly cannot be translated into contributory negligence," said the court in the judgement passed on July 8.

"Even if it is not being used for the purpose it is intended for, still it certainly cannot be used for driving, which is completely prohibited under the law," it held.

The accident, in the instant

case, took place on the pavement under the Madipur metro station in October 2015 at around 4:30 am when the truck, which was being driven at a high speed, hit four victims sleeping on the pavement there.

The court restored the 50 per cent deduction for contributory negligence, directing the insurer to pay the revised compensation within six weeks. It awarded around Rs 10 lakh each to the families of the two deceased and enhanced compensation for the two injured victims to Rs 1.2 lakh and Rs 18.1 lakh.

MPOST

Police await official clearance to withdraw NEET protest FIRs



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Following the Centre's assurance that cases against the NEET paper leak protesters would be withdrawn, Delhi Police sources on Sunday said it would take further action only after receiving official communication and guidelines from the competent authority.

The source said 15 FIRs have been registered so far at different police stations in the New Delhi district in connection with the July 20 violence and other incidents linked to the ongoing protests.

On Saturday, at a joint press conference with Cockroach Janata Party spokespersons Saurav Das and Abhishek Ranka, Union minister JP Nadda had said that the government agreed to withdraw FIRs registered against protesters and would provide a written assurance on the agreed demands by Tuesday.

"We will act according

to the guidelines and official communication after receiving from the competent authority," the source said.

The source, however, said the announcement regarding withdrawal of the cases would not affect the ongoing investigation into the alleged larger conspiracy behind the clashes.

Police are examining CCTV footage, digital evidence, mobile phone records, and statements of witnesses to reconstruct the sequence of events and identify those suspected of planning, instigating or participating in the violence. Police have also identified over 2,500 people with criminal backgrounds and bad characters using their facial recognition system (FRS). More than 200 police personnel and 70 protesters were injured during the July 20 clashes, while public property was damaged. Police said the conspiracy probe would continue regardless of the proposed withdrawal of FIRs.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: A surgery was performed allegedly on the wrong leg of a four-year-old ailing child at a government medical college in Nuh district, officials said on Sunday.

The mistake was discovered after the operation, and the procedure was then allegedly repeated on the correct leg -- that required surgery in the first place -- according to officials. The incident occurred at Shaheed Hasan Khan Mewati Government Medical College, Nalhar in Nuh district.

A complaint in this matter was registered by the child's father, and an inquiry into the alleged negligence has been initiated, the administration said.

According to complainant Arif, his four-year-old son was suffering from an abscess on his leg and was taken to the medical college on July 20.



The 4-yr-old's father claimed surgeon admitted error and later performed surgery on other leg

Subsequently, a surgery was performed on his right leg.

However, when the patient was wheeled out, the family realised that the wrong leg was operated upon, the complaint said. The child's father claimed that the surgeon admitted the error and later

VICTORY, THEN A NEW BATTLE

Student leaders celebrate win, pledge to expand movement

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A day after Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation brought an end to a 37-day student-led agitation at Jantar Mantar, protest leaders described the development as a victory for students while asserting that the movement would now expand beyond the national capital.

Manish Kumar, a PhD scholar at Allahabad University and Uttar Pradesh State President of the All India Students'

Association (AISA), called the resignation the movement's biggest achievement but maintained that the struggle would continue. "MPs and political leaders have assured us that this issue will be raised in Parliament. Beyond this, we will decentralise the movement across campuses, youth networks and citizens across the country to expose what we see as the government's anti-education policies," he said.

Responding to being described as an inspiration, Kumar said the movement was



never confined to one institution. While acknowledging JNU's long tradition of democratic resistance, he said the agitation represented a nationwide concern over education

and urged incoming students to safeguard public education, employment opportunities and democratic values.

Among the most recognizable faces of the protest was

Neha Bora, National President of AISA and a PhD scholar at Jawaharlal Nehru University's School of Arts and Aesthetics. A theatre practitioner by training, Bora emerged as one of the movement's most vocal leaders. She was among at least six students who launched an indefinite hunger strike at Jantar Mantar from a platform separate from the main stage, which the BJP had reserved as a non-partisan space where activist Sonam Wanchuk led his fast. Bora, along with Aameen Amtoj and Manish Kumar, ended

her 23-day hunger strike.

Calling the development "a victory for students, not politicians", Bora congratulated protesters across the country and said July 25 would be remembered as the day students compelled a government "to bow before democratic pressure". She also spoke about the challenges of participating in a prolonged protest as a woman, recalling inadequate sanitation facilities, undergoing medical examinations in public view and continuing the fast despite menstruation. Bora said she

hoped her participation would encourage more women and young people to occupy public spaces confidently and exercise their democratic right to dissent. Asked what she had as her first meal after ending the fast, she replied simple plate of dal chawal, saying it was all her body could manage after nearly four weeks without food.

CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka called the 37-day agitation a movement that "reawakened democracy", crediting students with securing the Minister's resignation.

NIRMAL JAIN TO HEAD MINORITIES COMMISSION

DCW gets new chief

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Ending a prolonged vacancy, the Delhi government on Sunday appointed Lata Gupta as the new Chairperson of the Delhi Commission for Women (DCW). Simultaneously, it appointed Nirmal Jain as the Chairman of the Delhi Minorities Commission.

As per the government order, Shyam Bala, Malti Verma, Lata Sodhi, Sanrakshika Sharma Jha and Renu Bhalla have been appointed as members of the Delhi Commission for Women. For the Delhi Minorities Commission Kuldeep Singh and Mohammad Haroon have been selected as its members.

While announcing the appointments, Delhi CM Office said that the Aam Aadmi Party government will strive to work for the dignity, rights and welfare of all sections of Delhi's population. It was mentioned that the new appointments were made to promote social harmony, inclusive development and support vulnerable communities in Delhi.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta congratulated the new chairpersons and members on assuming their new assignments. She tweeted that "the new DCW team will work



Lata Gupta, DCW Chairperson

HIGHLIGHTS

- » As per the government order, Shyam Bala, Malti Verma, Lata Sodhi, Sanrakshika Sharma Jha and Renu Bhalla have been appointed as members of the Delhi Commission for Women
- » For the Delhi Minorities Commission Kuldeep Singh and Mohammad Haroon have been selected as its members

closely with the Delhi government to work for women's safety and dignity and strengthen Delhi as a safe and caring city. The CM said in her post that she believes that the new DCW team will work closely with the government so as to protect women's rights and address various issues and challenges faced by women in the national capital.

While congratulating the new members of the Delhi Minorities Commission, the Chief Minister stated that she was confident that they will work with dedication to protect and promote the welfare of all sections of Delhi's population and work for the cause of inclusive development and social harmony in Delhi.

Delhi government also asserted that the appointments of the new Chairman and members of the Delhi Commission for Women (DCW) and Delhi Minorities Commission (DMC) would strengthen the functioning of the posts and enable faster resolution of issues related to women safety and welfare.

The government said that the presence of the new team would provide strength to the commission as a platform to advocate and address various challenges affecting women in Delhi.

774 schools found with safety deficiencies

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Following the directions issued by Lieutenant Governor Sardar TS Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during their review meeting held on July 6, 2026, comprehensive school safety inspections are underway across Delhi as part of Child Safety Month.

The inspections are being conducted for the strict and time-bound implementation of initiatives under the Student Safety Check List, framed in line with NCPCR and DCPCR guidelines and the POCSO Act.

The inspection drive covers Government, Government-aided, MCD/NDMC/DCB, and Private schools across the

TAKEAWAYS

- » The inspections are being conducted for the strict and time-bound implementation of initiatives under the Student Safety Check List, framed in line with NCPCR and DCPCR guidelines and the POCSO Act
- » Among government schools, 790 were inspected, with deficiencies identified in 270 schools. In the

private school category, 812 schools were inspected and 463 were found with deficiencies

» Private schools accounted for a disproportionately high share of deficiencies



currently under corrective follow-up. Among government schools, 790 were inspected, with deficiencies identified in 270 schools. In the private school category, 812 schools were inspected and 463 were found with deficiencies. A total of 75 government aided schools were also inspected, of which 41 had deficiencies. Private schools accounted for a disproportionately high share of deficiencies relative to the number inspected, an area that inspection teams continue to monitor closely.

The inspections are being carried out by dedicated teams across the Capital, with the pace and scale of the exercise increasing steadily. On several days, more than 150 to 200 schools were inspected in a sin-

gle day. Inspection teams comprise representatives of Parents, the Directorate of Education, the Women and Child Development Department, Delhi Police, and Heads of Schools. Schools found with deficiencies are being flagged for immediate remedial measures, with follow-up verification built into the process to ensure genuine compliance.

The drive will continue until all 5,633 schools in Delhi are covered, in line with the directions of the Lieutenant Governor and the Chief Minister to institutionalise child safety measures as a permanent feature of every school's functioning and to promote a sustained culture of safety, accountability, and preparedness across educational institutions.

Capital. According to the latest figures, a total of 1,677 schools have been inspected between

July 13 and July 24, 2026. Of these, 774 schools were found with deficiencies, which are

Mayor joins Mann Ki Baat

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi on Sunday joined residents and party workers of Booth 140 in Rohini Sector-8 for a collective listening session of the 136th episode of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's monthly radio programme, Mann Ki Baat. The gathering concluded with discussions on local development, governance and public welfare.

During the broadcast, the Prime Minister paid tribute to the soldiers who fought in the Kargil War, commemorating Kargil Vijay Diwas and highlighting their courage, patriotism and sacrifice. The address also underscored the importance of public service, civic responsibility and citizen participation in nation-building.

Addressing those present, Wahi said the sacrifice of the Kargil heroes continues to inspire every Indian and described Mann Ki Baat as a platform that encourages constructive social change and reinforces citizens' responsibilities towards the nation.

The Mayor said the vision of a Viksit Bharat could only be realised through active public participation and urged citizens to contribute towards cleanliness, social responsibility, community service and public welfare alongside government efforts. Following the programme, Wahi held an informal interaction over a tiffin meeting with local residents and party workers. Discussions focused on organisational matters, civic issues, local development initiatives and measures to improve public welfare. He also sought suggestions from residents on strengthening civic services and governance at the grassroots level. Stressing the importance of public engagement, Wahi said continuous dialogue between elected representatives and citizens was essential for effective governance. He appealed to residents to actively participate in community initiatives and contribute towards the broader goal of building a developed and inclusive India through collective action.

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government's Department of Social Welfare has launched a structured internship programme that will allow students to gain hands-on experience at government-run institutions for senior citizens and persons with disabilities. The initiative is aimed at combining classroom learning with practical exposure while helping students better understand the challenges faced by vulnerable sections of society.

According to the guidelines issued by the department, the programme is open to students enrolled in undergraduate and postgraduate courses such as Social Work, Psychology, Sociology, Rehabilitation Sciences, Nursing, Law, Special Education and other social welfare-related disciplines. Preference will be given to students who have completed their second year or fourth semester.

The department said the

HANDS-ON EXPERIENCE

- » The initiative is aimed at combining classroom learning with practical exposure while helping students better understand the challenges faced by vulnerable sections of society
- » The internships are intended to bridge the gap between academic knowledge and field experience, improve employability and foster empathy and social responsibility
- » Selected students are likely to be placed at facilities such as Asha Kiran in Rohini, old-age homes and hostels for visually impaired students operated by the department

internships are intended to bridge the gap between academic knowledge and field experience, improve employability and foster empathy and social responsibility among students. Interns will have the option to choose between two categories. The Field-Based Internship will involve direct engagement with residents of government institutions, including assisting in daily care, rehabilitation activities, counselling support and recreational programmes. Students may also observe behavioural

changes, maintain records and assist officials in institutional work. The Research Internship, which excludes direct work with persons with disabilities, will focus on case studies, surveys and the evaluation of welfare schemes and institutional services to strengthen evidence-based policymaking.

Selected students are likely to be placed at facilities such as Asha Kiran in Rohini, old-age homes and hostels for visually impaired students operated by the department.

To safeguard the privacy

and dignity of residents, the department has prescribed a strict code of conduct. Interns will not be permitted to take photographs or videos inside institutions without prior approval from the competent authority. They will also be barred from sharing photographs, reports or any information related to residents or institutions on social media platforms, blogs or other public forums.

Applications can be submitted either directly by students or through their educational institutions. Applicants must furnish a recommendation letter from their college explaining the purpose of the internship. The final selection will be made by the Head of the Department of Social Welfare.

The internship will be offered free of cost, but participants will not receive any stipend or honorarium. Students will also be required to submit a report upon completion of the programme.

After protest, a swift clean-up



ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) launched a large-scale cleanliness, restoration and beautification drive at Jantar Mantar immediately after the conclusion of the recent protest, removing nearly 60 metric tonnes of waste and restoring public infrastructure overnight.

NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal remained at the site throughout the night to supervise the operation and later revisited the area on Sunday afternoon to review the completed work. According to the civic body, more than 500 officers and employees from the Health and Sanitation, Civil Engineering, and Horticulture departments participated in the drive.

The operation covered Jantar Mantar and adjoining areas,

NDMC Vice-Chairperson remained at the site throughout the night to supervise the operation and later revisited the area on Sunday to review the completed work

including Tolstoy Road, Sansad Marg, Jai Singh Road, Janpath and parts of Connaught Place. Officials said sanitation teams carried out intensive cleaning, road washing and waste removal, while engineering staff repaired damaged footpaths and kerbstones, removed slogans from public walls and repainted affected surfaces. The horticulture department restored green belts, central verges and landscaped areas.

The sanitation drive involved 75 workers overnight, with 35 more joining during the day. The operation was supported by eight auto-tippers, two heavy trucks, one JCB and three high-pressure jetting machines. Around 50 civil engineering workers were also deployed for restoration work.

Chahal said NDMC teams became operational immediately after the protest ended and completed the cleaning before any subsequent symbolic activities at the site. He commended sanitation workers and field staff for working through the night and urged citizens to help maintain cleanliness and protect public property. He added that the council would continue to respond swiftly after major public gatherings to restore public spaces for residents and visitors.

'NO PANIC ANYMORE'

This is just the beginning: Dipke

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A day after leading one of the country's most talked-about youth movements to a major political victory, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke finally allowed himself a rare moment of rest.

Following Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak and the Centre's acceptance of the CJP's key demands, the 30-year-old activist shared a video message on Sunday reflecting on the movement that transformed a satirical campaign into a nationwide youth uprising. Describing the past 37 days as among the most challenging of his life, Dipke said the biggest change for him was the return of normalcy.

"For the first time in weeks, I could sleep peacefully in my own room without constantly worrying about what the next few hours would bring. The sense of panic is finally gone," he said.

Calling the agitation "extremely difficult," Dipke said



the conclusion of the protest was not the end of the movement but the beginning of a much larger journey.

"This is only the trailer. The Cockroach Janta Party still has a long road ahead, and our work is far from over," he said.

Dipke founded the CJP in May after a remark by the Chief Justice of India referring to unemployed youth as "cockroaches" sparked widespread debate. What began as a satirical response soon evolved into

a national movement, drawing thousands of students and young people demanding accountability over the NEET paper leak, alleged examination irregularities and broader reforms in India's education system.

For over a month, Jantar Mantar remained the centre of the agitation as protesters gathered from across the country, raising slogans and demanding Pradhan's resignation while pressing for systemic reforms.

The campaign culminated on Saturday when Pradhan resigned, the Centre agreed to withdraw cases against peaceful protesters, accepted other key demands and the CJP called off its 36-day protest.

Dipke thanked everyone who stood with the movement throughout the agitation, especially those who remained at Jantar Mantar despite difficult conditions.

"I sincerely appreciate every person who stayed with this movement and contributed in whatever way they could. What you did was for the country, and I will always be grateful," he said.

Revealing that he was battling typhoid and fever, Dipke apologised for being unable to personally thank supporters during Saturday's celebrations.

He also acknowledged his critics, saying constructive criticism and difficult questions helped strengthen both the movement and its leadership.

"Many people questioned us, and that pushed us to improve. Those conversations made us stronger and helped us deliver what we had promised," he said.

MCD bags top civic honour

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has won the First Prize for Outstanding Contribution to Urban Civic Services and Public Welfare at the Delhi Government Achievements & Schemes Expo 2026, held at Bharat Mandapam, Pragati Maidan.

The expo featured 71 stalls representing government departments, public sector undertakings and other organisations. MCD emerged as the top exhibitor for showcasing its initiatives aimed at improving civic services, public welfare and urban governance.

According to the civic body, its stall attracted a large number of visitors, including students, residents and representatives from various institutions, who explored the corporation's flagship programmes and citizen-focused initiatives. The exhibition highlighted MCD's efforts to enhance public service delivery through digital governance, environmental management and public awareness campaigns.

Several key departments participated in the MCD pavilion, including the Property Tax Department, the Department



of Environment Management Services (DEMS), the Veterinary Services Department and the Public Health Department. The stall featured interactive displays, working models, information panels and awareness material explaining ongoing projects, digital initiatives and civic services available to residents.

Officials said the exhibition served as a platform to demonstrate the corporation's efforts towards improving urban infrastructure, environmental sus-

tainability, public health and municipal service delivery.

The civic body expressed gratitude to the organisers for the recognition and said the award reflects the collective efforts of its departments in strengthening governance and improving citizen services. MCD reaffirmed its commitment to delivering transparent, efficient and citizen-friendly municipal services while continuing to adopt innovative approaches to address the evolving needs of the national capital.

First Tree Walk at Delhi Zoo documents 35 tree species

NEW DELHI: The National Zoological Park (Delhi Zoo) organised its first-ever "Tree Walk @ NZP" on Sunday from 7:30 am to 10 am, an initiative to promote awareness about urban biodiversity and encourage public participation in documenting the city's flora.

During the walk through the zoo campus, led by naturalist and wildlife photographer Sanjay Tiwari, participants documented 35 tree species, including several native varieties that support birds, butterflies, insects and other wildlife, according to a statement.

Experts explained methods of identifying trees based on features such as leaves, bark, flowers, fruits and canopy structure, it stated.

Participants, including nature enthusiasts, students, interns and volunteers, were also introduced to the ecological benefits of trees, such as carbon sequestration, air purification, temperature regulation, soil conservation and their role in providing habitats for diverse species, it said.

The zoo also organised the seventh edition of its "Sunday Bird Walk @ NZP" led by bird expert Nikhil Devasar.

Participants recorded 44 bird species during the exercise, highlighting the avian diversity within the zoo campus. The statement said the Tree Walk is part of its efforts to strengthen environmental education, biodiversity conservation and citizen science initiatives.

The zoo announced it will organise a "Reptiles, Amphibians and Molluscs Walk @ NZP" on August 2 alongside its regular Sunday Bird Walk to familiarise participants with the diversity of reptiles, amphibians and molluscs found within the zoo.

Registration for the nature walks is mandatory and open to individuals aged 18 years and above on a first-come, first-served basis via the National Zoological Park's website and the NZP Saathi mobile application. The zoo also offers other walks, including bird walks, butterfly and dragonfly walks, spider and insect walks, and moth watch activities, it said. AGENCIES

STUDENTS WERE STAGING PROTEST IN SEVERAL STATES

CJP-led protest: SC to hear today pleas alleging police excesses on students

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court is slated to hear on Monday two separate pleas alleging police excesses against students protesting over NEET paper leak and other exam irregularities. According to the apex court's cause list of July 27, the pleas would come up for hearing before a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana. A bench headed by the CJI had on July 24 agreed to hear these petitions after the matter was mentioned before it.

"Police is using excessive force against the students," senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan had told the bench while mentioning the pleas for urgent listing. Sankaranarayanan had told the bench that two separate petitions were filed regarding the violence that took place during students' protests across the



Injured protesters who were allegedly hurt during clashes with security personnel on Monday, at Jantar Mantar during an ongoing demonstration over the NEET issue, in New Delhi

country.

The CJI had said that the pleas would be listed for hearing on July 27. Students were staging protests in several states against the paper leak. The Cockroach Janta Party-led march on July 20 in Delhi witnessed clashes between protesters and security personnel, who used lathis and tear gas shells to disperse crowds attempting to move towards Parliament.

The protesters were demanding the resignation of Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET paper leak issue. On Saturday, the CJP called off its 36-day agitation after

Highlights

- » According to the apex court's cause list of July 27, the pleas would come up for hearing before a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana
- » On Saturday, the CJP called off its 36-day agitation after Pradhan resigned and the government accepted its other demands
- » On July 22, the Delhi High Court had sought responses from the Centre and the Delhi Police on two separate pleas alleging excessive use of force against protesters

PTI

Assam: 4 workers killed in cylinder blast at factory in Cachar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SILCHAR: At least four workers were killed in a suspected cylinder explosion at an iron casting unit in Cachar district of Assam on Sunday, police said. The incident took place in the afternoon at a shared compound of Kade Global Infrastructure LLP and IRID Casting Works LLP in Pangram under Udharbond police station limits, a senior officer said. "A sudden explosion shattered the factory and several people suffered injuries. They were taken to Silchar Medical College and Hospital, where four people were declared dead," he said.

According to preliminary investigation, the explosion was caused by an LPG cylinder engaged in casting work, the officer said. The four deceased have been identified as Kiran Munda, Appu Baraik, Shyamal Gour and Sagar Nath, the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) said.

Expressing condolence over the deaths, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the government is strictly monitoring the situation, and has apprehended four individuals. "Industrial negligence will not be tolerated and we will take firm action against any lapses," he said. The Cachar district police are investigating the case from the safety lapse angle, and have detained the manager and three others for questioning, the CMO said. "I have asked Shri @RajdeepGoala14, MLA to meet the families and extend all assistance they need in this tough time. We will offer the families Rs 5 lakh each under CM Relief Fund," Sarma said. Assam Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Kaushik Rai went to the spot and reviewed the situation. He said that Rs 5 lakh each to the next of kin of the deceased has been sanctioned by the chief minister.

Rath Yatra: Devotees throng as 'Adhar Pana' ritual performed on chariots in Puri

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PURI: Thousands of devotees on Sunday witnessed the 'Adhar Pana' ritual of the Rath Yatra, where sweet drink is offered to Lord Balabhadra, Devi Subhadra and Lord Jagannath on the chariots here in front of the 12th-century temple. The sweet drink, after being offered to the deities on chariots in earthen pots, is broken, and it flows on the floor of

the chariots for the subsidiary deities and spirits, believed to accompany the trinity - Lord Balabhadra, Devi Subhadra and Lord Jagannath- during the annual Rath Yatra. Gajapati Maharaja Dibyasingha Deb, the titular king of Puri, in a recent interview, said that Lord Jagannath, as the nomenclature signifies, is not the God of human beings alone. "He is the master of all things like animals, birds, trees,

plants, living and disembodied souls. When human beings get his 'mahaprasad' all along the year, it is the only occasion during Rath Yatra when spirits and invisible souls also get their thirst quenched through these sweet drinks called 'adhar pana,' he explained. The ritual is conducted on all three chariots—Nandighosa (Lord Jagannath), Taladhwaia (Lord Balabhadra) and Darpadalana (Devi Subhadra)—after the completion of Suna



Besha (golden attire) and on the 12th day of the Asadha

ble souls, as per the scriptures, could not enter the temple even though they do not have bodies, said Shree Jagannath culture researcher Bhaskar Mishra. On Sunday, the 'Adhar Pana' ritual was held, during which pots filled with sweet water were offered to the sibling deities. "It is named as 'Adhar Pana' as the huge earthen pots touch the 'adhar' (lips) of the sibling deities. 'Pana' means sweet drinks,"

Mishra said, adding that the pots were later broken on the chariot and sweet drinks spills on the floor of the chariots. As per the tradition, water is brought from a well near 'Chhauni Matha'. Then Pana is prepared with milk cream, cheese, sugar, banana, camphor, nutmeg, black pepper and other spices, before being offered to the deities. Nine earthen pots filled with sweet water, three for each deity, are placed touching their lips.

From Page 1

Aadhaar architect

Intelligence Bureau director Tapan Deka, IIT Madras director V. Kamakoti, former education secretary Anita Karwal and logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena. Nilekani is widely known as the architect of Aadhaar and one of the key figures behind India's digital public infrastructure. The announcement follows weeks of protests led by the CJP, which had been staging a sit-in at Delhi's Jantar Mantar since June 20. The group demanded Pradhan's resignation, accountability for the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, action over alleged irregularities in the CBSE's on-screen marking process and broader reforms in the conduct of public examinations. The agitation drew support from thousands of students across the country as well as several opposition parties. Public attention intensified about two weeks into the protest after videos showing activist Sonam Wangchuk's deteriorating health during his fast circulated widely on social media. On July 18, Delhi Police shifted Wangchuk to Safdarjung Hospital, a move that triggered widespread anger among students and protesters.

The situation escalated further on July 20, when a large protest march towards Parliament was met with a strong police response that included lathicharge and the use of tear gas. Following three rounds of discussions, the government and the CJP reached an agreement on Saturday, leading the organisation to withdraw its agitation. Along with accepting Pradhan's resignation, the Centre also agreed to provide what it described as "honourable" compensation to the families of students who allegedly died by suicide and to withdraw FIRs registered against protesters in Delhi and other BJP-ruled states. The Centre is also set to introduce the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, in the Lok Sabha on Monday. The proposed legislation seeks to strengthen the existing anti-paper leak law by establishing fast-track courts in every state for paper leak cases and requiring investigations to be completed within two months. The bill also proposes stricter punishment for those involved in examination fraud. Individuals found guilty of paper leaks could face imprisonment of up to

10 years and fines of up to Rs 50 lakh, while organised paper leak rackets could attract penalties of up to Rs 10 crore.

The twin announcements of the reform panel and tougher legislation mark the Centre's latest effort to rebuild trust in the country's examination system after months of protests and widespread concern among students over the integrity of public examinations.

Pralhad Joshi

and held detailed discussions with the senior officers. It is a very big department, so I will speak in detail after I have understood it completely," he told reporters. Later, in a post on X, Joshi thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi for placing his trust in him. "Today, I assumed charge as the Union Minister for Education. I am grateful to Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi ji for placing his faith in me and entrusting me with this responsibility. I accept it with humility and a deep sense of duty," he wrote.

A Rashtrapati Bhavan statement said the President accepted Pradhan's resignation with immediate effect under Article 75(2) of the Constitution and assigned the Education Ministry to Joshi in addition to his current responsibilities.

In his resignation letter, Pradhan said the issue was not one of "individual prestige" and that he was deeply disturbed by the developments of the past 10 days. Joshi currently serves as the Union Minister for Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution and New and Renewable Energy. He has earlier held the Coal, Mines and Parliamentary Affairs portfolios.

Opposition to corner

students, and if not, who had done so. Gandhi also sought clarification on whether individuals seen beating students while dressed in plain clothes were police personnel or volunteers, and who had authorised their deployment. Ramesh said the home minister must answer these questions in Parliament and repeated the Congress demand that the prime minister apologise to the students. The Congress has described Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as a victory for the student movement but maintained that the government's response remains incomplete.

Kharge said it was now Modi's turn to apologise and take strict action against those who allegedly used lathis, batons and pellet guns on protesters.

After Pradhan stepped down, Gandhi said the resignation marked a major step towards rebuilding the education system, though he called it only a symbolic beginning. Ramesh also said the party would continue pressing for accountability for those responsible for the alleged excesses.

Parliament is expected to witness a sharp debate if the deadlock between the treasury and opposition benches ends. The amendment bill proposes tougher punishments for examination fraud. Individuals found guilty of paper leaks or other unfair means could face imprisonment ranging from five to 10 years and fines of up to Rs 50 lakh. Organised exam fraud would attract a minimum seven-year jail term and fines of up to Rs 10 crore.

The current law, enacted in 2024 amid widespread paper leak controversies, provides for imprisonment of three to five years for cheating offences and five to 10 years, along with a minimum Rs 1 crore fine, for organised crimes. Before that legislation, there was no dedicated law dealing with unfair practices in central government examinations. The new bill has been listed for introduction, consideration and passage in the Lok Sabha on Monday, an uncommon scheduling practice.

The government decided to amend the law after protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) over the alleged NEET paper leak gathered momentum, while opposition protests over the issue disrupted Parliament during the first week of the session.

The opposition has not yet announced whether it will support the bill. Gandhi said on Saturday that the Congress would decide its position only after consultations within the INDIA bloc, adding that the alliance functions through consensus in Parliament.

Following the resignation of the education minister and the government's acceptance of its other demands, the CJP on Saturday ended its 36-day agitation. Earlier, Modi had promised a law to tackle examination paper leaks and said those accused in such cases would face trial in fast-track courts.

SC judge

to protest or express opinions, Justice Bhuyan said there was growing concern over "normal activities" being treated as criminal offences.

"It will not be an exaggeration to say that public space for expressing divergent opinion is shrinking in India. The right to express one's views and the right to demonstrate peacefully are fundamental freedoms of citizens. Debate and dissent are the essence of democracy. Unfortunately, even normal activities are being criminalised," he said.

Justice Bhuyan cited the case of 14 Muslim men who were arrested after consuming chicken biryani while breaking their Ramadan fast on a boat in the Ganga. The group remained in jail for nearly three months before obtaining relief.

"I am sure consuming chicken biryani is not an offence. There is no law prohibiting consumption of chicken over the Ganga River. They were arrested for that very reason and they had to remain in jail for three months. Can people be arrested and denied bail for three months for such an activity? I ask myself. Citizens are watching; people are watching," he said.

According to Justice Bhuyan, such incidents raise broader questions about the criminal justice system's response to peaceful conduct. While courts often grant bail in these cases, he said the relief frequently comes after considerable delay.

He also questioned the conditions imposed while granting bail, saying they could discourage citizens from exercising their democratic rights. Referring to cases where accused persons were barred from attending public meetings, posting on social media or leaving the country, Justice Bhuyan asked whether such restrictions indirectly discouraged people from expressing dissent.

"These issues raise serious questions. Citizens are finding that though the courts are responsive and do grant bail, do grant relief, many a times it is belated. But it is the restrictive conditions which are imposed while granting bail that are causing the greatest concern. By such restrictive orders, are the courts indirectly telling the citizens or discouraging the citizens not to express their dissent?" he said.

Justice Bhuyan also referred to a July 2025 Bombay High Court order that rejected a petition filed by the Communist Party of India (Marxist) seeking permission to hold a demonstration at Mumbai's Azad Maidan against the alleged genocide in Gaza.

Recalling the observations made during the hearing, he said he found it "very amusing" that a judge questioned why citizens wished to protest over an international humanitarian issue. The High Court had remarked that India had enough domestic issues to address and suggested that protesting over Gaza was not an act

of patriotism.

Turning to the role of the judiciary, Justice Bhuyan said judges and courts were not beyond public scrutiny. He encouraged students, lawyers and the legal fraternity to critically analyse judicial decisions, saying criticism of a judgment should not be seen as criticism of the judge who delivered it.

"Judgments, after being delivered, are required to be critically examined and criticised if necessary. Criticism of a judgment does not amount to criticism of a judge," he said.

Referring to important Supreme Court rulings, including the judgment on reservation for the Economically Weaker Sections (EWS), Justice Bhuyan urged law students not to accept court decisions without examination.

"If everybody goes and tells the judges, 'Sir, wonderful thing. Sir, what you say is excellent. Sir, you are a jurist; then how will the system improve?'" he asked.

Justice Bhuyan concluded by saying that the judiciary's legitimacy depends on public confidence rather than self-praise. He said judges must constantly introspect if they wish to remain relevant and trusted, adding that it is ultimately citizens, not judges themselves, who determine the standing of the Supreme Court and the judiciary in a democratic society.

Return to routine

diagnosed with typhoid, remained at home recuperating, while environmentalist Sonam Wangchuk, who had joined the movement with an indefinite hunger strike, continued his recovery at Medanta Hospital.

In a video message shared by the CJP, Dipke reflected on the intensity of the past five weeks, describing them as among the most demanding days of his life.

"For the first time in weeks, I woke up without constantly thinking about the next challenge or what the day would bring. It feels peaceful, and the sense of urgency that had become routine is finally gone," he said.

The protest began on June 20, with the CJP demanding accountability over the NEET paper leak, alleged irregularities in the examination process and wider reforms in India's education system. The movement gained nationwide attention after police action against protesters during the July 20 'Sansad Chalo' march and drew support from students, civil

society groups and activists, including Wangchuk.

On Saturday, after the Centre accepted the CJP's remaining demands, including withdrawal of FIRs against peaceful protesters and compensation for families of students who allegedly died by suicide following the NEET controversy, the organisation announced the immediate withdrawal of the agitation.

Looking back on the movement, Dipke expressed gratitude to supporters who stood with the CJP despite doubts over its campaign.

"Thousands of people believed in this movement when many questioned it. Their trust and determination made this victory possible, and I will always remain grateful to them," he said.

Revealing that he had been battling typhoid and high fever during the final phase of the protest, Dipke apologised for being unable to personally meet supporters after Saturday's celebrations.

"I wanted to thank everyone in person, but my health didn't permit it. Even then, every person who stood at Jantar Mantar and every supporter across the country has my deepest appreciation," he said.

Dipke also acknowledged those who criticised the movement, saying difficult questions and public scrutiny helped strengthen the campaign.

"Criticism pushed us to improve. It made us reflect, correct ourselves where needed and emerge stronger," he said. Calling the successful agitation only the beginning of a larger journey, he reiterated that the CJP would continue engaging with young people across the country and work towards broader education reforms.

Meanwhile, civic authorities began restoring normalcy around Jantar Mantar. The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) launched an extensive clean-up operation, deploying more than 100 sanitation workers along with mechanised equipment and heavy vehicles to remove nearly 60 metric tonnes of waste generated during the month-long protest.

Officials said around 52 metric tonnes of waste had been cleared by Sunday afternoon, while roads were washed using pressure-jetting machines, walls carrying protest slogans were repainted and damaged footpaths and kerbstones repaired as the capital's most prominent protest site returned to routine after witnessing one of the country's most significant youth-led movements in recent years.

Army evacuates 790 persons after heavy rains in Gujarat, Dadra & Nagar Haveli

OUR CORRESPONDENT

AHMEDABAD: The Indian Army has carried out rescue missions in flood-hit districts of south Gujarat, Ahmedabad, and the Union Territory of Dadra and Nagar Haveli, evacuating more than 790 stranded persons from inundated and inaccessible areas, officials said on Sunday.

Incessant rains battered south Gujarat on July 21 and 22, and covered several parts of the state during the next few days. Thirty-five rain-related deaths, including 29 in Valsad and Navsari, two of the worst affected districts, were reported in Gujarat over the last few days, officials earlier said.

The Southern Command of the Indian Army launched the humanitarian assistance and disaster relief operations on the evening of July 23.

Manipur govt's performance dipped post-Prez rule: BJP MLA's veiled attack on CM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IMPHAL: Manipur's ruling BJP MLA L. Susindro Meitei on Sunday launched a veiled attack on Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh, claiming that the state government's performance dipped after the President's Rule was lifted in February.

Meitei, a minister under previous CM N. Biren Singh before President's Rule was imposed in the ethnic violence-affected state early last year, also said he may be compelled to leave the BJP if the functioning of the government continues to be "unsatisfactory".

"The government is run by a few ministers, and we only interact when they call for a discussion on certain issues," the Khurai constituency legislator said.

Meitei claimed that not only he, but the people of the northeastern state also want the government to function by understanding public interests.

"The performance graph of the government did not fall much when I was part of the council of ministers, as well as during the period of the President's Rule. That performance graph has now declined after the new government came as it failed to meet the expectations of the people," he said, without naming the current CM.

The former consumer affairs, food and public distribution minister neither cited any instance nor specified why the government's performance dropped.

"I am not a part of the government, but I am still a member of the ruling party. However, if the current system of governance continues to be unsatisfactory, I may have to leave the party," he said.

At least 260 people have been killed and thousands rendered homeless since May 2023 due to ethnic violence in Manipur between the valley-based Meiteis and the Kukis who live in the hill districts.

Following continued ethnic clashes and the resignation of Chief Minister N. Biren Singh, the state was placed under President's Rule on February 13, 2025. It was lifted nearly a year later, on February 4.

MONTHLY RADIO BROADCAST 'MANN KI BAAT'

PM Modi says India scaling new heights in defence production

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday asserted that India is continuously scaling new heights in defence production, military exports and also in the field of political cooperation with friendly nations.

Addressing his monthly radio broadcast 'Mann Ki Baat', he also paid tributes to those who sacrificed their lives during the Kargil war in 1999.

The Prime Minister, however, did not refer to the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led protests on the NEET paper leak issue which concluded on Saturday after the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Education minister and acceptance of the protesters' other demands by the government.

Recording of the Mann Ki Baat is normally done two to three days ahead of the scheduled broadcast.



former Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, BJP National General Secretary Vinod Tawde, and others, listen to PM Modi's 'Mann Ki Baat' radio programme, in New Delhi

Referring to the 'Kargil Vijay Diwas', the Prime Minister said there are certain days in people's lives that do not require a calendar to be remembered.

"Today, the 26th of July, is one such date. Today is 'Kargil Vijay Diwas'. This day fills us with pride. This day reminds us

of the extraordinary courage of our brave soldiers.

"Towering peaks of Kargil, harsh weather, the challenge posed by the enemy - our soldiers faced every such circumstance, yet their spirit was greater than every challenge," he said.

Modi said India of today

Highlights

» Referring to the 'Kargil Vijay Diwas', the Prime Minister said there are certain days in people's lives that do not require a calendar to be remembered

» Talking about the campaign 'Catch The Rain' for the conservation of rainwater, Modi said the message is very simple: conserve the water right where and when the rain falls

not only remembers her heroes but also conveys their saga to the new generation and, with this very sentiment, a special 'Shaurya Vijay Yatra' has been organised this year.

The prime minister said alongside the courage of the soldiers, India is also continuously strengthening its techno-

logical capabilities.

He said a few days ago, INS Mahendragiri was inducted into the Indian Navy and this modern warship has been designed and built in India itself. "More than 75 per cent of the materials used in it are indigenous. It is a symbol of the growing strength of an 'Atmanirbhar Bharat,'" he said.

Modi said the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) also successfully tested the Pinaka Long-Range Guided Rocket this month and behind this success lies the collective perseverance of the scientists and engineers.

Only two-three days ago, the DRDO also successfully tested the Kusha missile, he said. "Whether it is defence production, defence exports, or political cooperation with friendly nations, India is continuously scaling new heights," he said.

Won't contest 2028 Karnataka Assembly polls: Siddaramaiah

Former CM says politics has become deeply polluted today

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Siddaramaiah

BENGALURU: Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Sunday announced that he will not contest the 2028 Assembly polls, citing advancing age, politics becoming "deeply polluted".

The Congress Working Committee member, however, asserted that he will remain active in politics and continue to be a voice for the people's hardship and well-being.

"Politics has become deeply polluted today, and for that reason I will not contest the 2028 Assembly elections. However, I will remain active in politics and continue to be a voice for the people's hardships and well-being," Siddaramaiah said in a post on 'X', detailing what he said at a private event held on Saturday in K R Pet in Mandya district.

Noting that the people of the Varuna constituency in Mysuru are urging him to contest the elections once again,

he said, "I have decided that I should not contest any more elections. Earlier, when I contested elections, it was the people of the constituency who supported us financially and ensured our victory. Today, that situation no longer exists."

"I am now 79-years-old. Our (Congress) government's term has another year and a half remaining. By then, I will be 81-82 years old. My health may not remain as strong as it is now, and I may not be able to work with the same energy and enthusiasm as before," he added.

Siddaramaiah resigned as Chief Minister on May 28, following instructions from the Congress high command, paving the way for D K Shivakumar to take over as CM.

Following his resignation, Siddaramaiah had said that he "politely declined" the Congress high command's Rajya Sabha seat offer, asserting that he would remain in state politics, and was not interested in national politics.

Pointing out that by 2028, he will be 82 years old, Siddaramaiah said at that time, he will have completed 50 years in public life.

"I began my political career in 1978 as a Taluk Board member. I have seen both victory and defeat, but I have the satisfaction of never acting against the principles I believed in or betraying my conscience," he said. A time has now come when politicians have to pay money to the people if they want to contest elections, the Congress leader said.

GANDHI WRITES TO HOME MINISTER

'Did you approve use of lethal force, pellet guns?' Rahul asks Amit Shah

NEW DELHI: Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi has written to Union Home minister Amit Shah, demanding accountability for the "barbaric assault" on peacefully protesting students here and asking whether he approved the use of "lethal force", including pellet guns, against the youth.

In his letter to Shah, Gandhi said peaceful protest is crucial to any democracy, and it is the government's responsibility to protect protestors and resolve their grievances through dialogue.

"Such brutal violence destroys every norm, and has outraged the country. Youth and students, the future of our country, are demanding answers and

Gandhi said peaceful protest is crucial to any democracy and it is gov't responsibility to protect protestors

accountability. Their voice will be heard," the former Congress chief said.

"I write to demand accountability for the barbaric assault on students who were peacefully protesting in Delhi on July 20, 2026. Our students were demanding a fair and accountable education system. Instead of being heard, security forces

assaulted them with indiscriminate force, including lethal weapons and tear gas," Gandhi said in his letter dated July 25.

"Hundreds have suffered serious injuries and women students have been assaulted by policemen, including by deliberately targeting their private parts," he stated.

Gandhi said the most shocking has been the use of pellet guns. "Reports in the media and social media clearly show people who have suffered grave injuries, including a journalist. I met 19-year-old student Sahil Lochab, who is now in severe pain and is likely to lose an eye because he was shot with pellet guns," he said.

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Sunday said the Jantar Mantar and other protests in recent weeks have had proximate causes in a rigged exam system but the agony and anger of youth and their parents have more fundamental causes of both accessibility and affordability revealed by household expenditure data.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said the youth and their parents are crying out for remedial action on accessibility and affordability.

"The Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) has very recently done a detailed analysis based on its household expenditure data between

Closer Look

» Education costs are rising substantially faster than household income, said Ramesh

» 'Private tuition has emerged as one of the fastest-growing components of household expenditure on education'

2014/15-2025/26. The conclusions are stark. Education costs are rising substantially faster than household income. Households are allocating a considerably larger share of their income towards education.

"Private tuition has emerged as one of the fastest-growing components of household expenditure on education. School and college fees have recorded sustained growth throughout the last decade, con-

sistently outpacing household income growth," Ramesh said, citing CMIE analysis.

He further said spending on books is rising even faster that may reflect rising textbook and reference material prices, greater spending on competitive exam preparations, and on supplementary learning resources.

"The Jantar Mantar and other protests in recent weeks have had proximate causes in an unfair and rigged exam system

put in place by the deadly duo of Pradhan Mantri and (ex-) Mantri Pradhan. But the agony, anguish, and anger of youth and their parents have more fundamental causes of both accessibility and affordability revealed by the CMIE household expenditure data," Ramesh said.

"They are crying out for remedial action NOW," he added.

His remarks come a day after Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned amid mounting pressure over the NEET paper leak controversy, with the Centre conceding the principal demand of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP)-led agitation after weeks of protests that spread from the national capital to several parts of the country.

NEET PAPER LEAK ROW

Tej Pratap 'jailed' for supporting Bihar bandh; Tejashwi, Kishor support him

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PATNA: Former Bihar minister Tej Pratap Yadav was on Sunday sent to jail for trying to enforce the state-wide bandh called a day ago by students' unions over the NEET paper leak, his lawyer claimed.

The alleged "wrongful arrest" led his estranged younger brother Tejashwi, the RJD working president who is said to have played a role in his expulsion from the party headed by their father Lalu Prasad a year ago, to come out in his support.

According to Jagannath Singh, the lawyer of Tej

Pratap Yadav, who now heads Janshakti Janata Dal, the ex-minister has been sent to the Beur Central Jail on the outskirts of the city, after being remanded to judicial custody by a magistrate.

"But the fact remains that he was arrested from a Patna mall at 7.30 pm yesterday and the FIR got lodged at the police station concerned only around 12.15 am on Sunday. Tomorrow, I shall be moving before a competent court for bail, where I will also highlight the anomaly," the lawyer said.

The police did not comment on Tej Pratap Yadav's "wrongful" arrest.

Notably, Yadav has been booked for supporting the Bihar bandh called by Left-wing students' unions over the NEET paper leak issue.

Tejashwi Yadav, who returned to the city after a long vacation abroad, flew into a rage upon learning about the arrest of "my big brother".

Jan Suraj Party founder Prashant Kishor, who is engaged in a fierce electoral battle with the BJP in the bypoll to Bankipur Assembly seat, vacated by the saffron party's national president Nitin Nabin, claimed that Tej Pratap Yadav was "being targeted for supporting me".

Pradhan's resign: BJP MP's daughter's social media post sparks ire

BHUBANESWAR: A social media post of Bhubaneswar MP Aparajita Sarangi's daughter Archita Sachin Rahar allegedly celebrating the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as the Union education minister has sparked resentment in the party rank and file in Odisha.

Rahar, in an Instagram post, which had a photograph of Pradhan in the backdrop of the national flag, wrote, "Dharmendra Pradhan resigns amid massive student protests over NEET leak fiasco".

State BJP leaders, including her mother, on the other hand, expressed sympathy to Pradhan.

"Everyone has the right to express their views. Her daughter, who is from Gen Z, said she stands by her statement. She has the right to speak her mind," the MP's office assistant Dhaneswar Barik told news agency over phone.

Asked whether Rahar's social media post has put the Bhubaneswar MP in trouble, Barik said, "Only time will tell."

The two-time MP from Bhubaneswar was, however, unavailable for comment.

Sources said the lawmaker had asked her daughter to remove the post after getting a phone call from Pradhan's office. However, it failed to have an impact.

Rahar, in another social media post, wrote, "Also, to DP's PA who is sure to text my mother asking me to delete my previous story (it has happened before) -- Don't bother. I won't delete. Jai Jagannath! Jai Hind." POST

Nation Briefs

RAHUL GANDHI TO VISIT TAMIL NADU ON AUGUST 1

CHENNAI: Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, is scheduled to visit Tamil Nadu on August 1, TNCC Chief B Manickam Tagore said on Sunday. The visit gains significance as this comes after the party taken part in the TVK-led government's cabinet. Although the exact itinerary has not yet been disclosed, the visit is being closely watched since the timing coincides with the protests against the NEET gaining traction in the state, despite Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigning after the protest over the NEET paper leak in the national capital. Confirming the visit, Tagore in a social media post said that Tamil Nadu is gearing up to extend an enthusiastic welcome to the Opposition leader.

NC SEEKS APOLOGY FOR MEHBOOBA REMARK ON VIOLENCE AGAINST KASHMIRIS

SRINAGAR: Peoples Democratic Party president Mehbooba Mufti has triggered a political storm after drawing a parallel between the Gen-Z protesters at Delhi's Jantar Mantar and the agitators in Kashmir, asserting that force was justified in the Valley to fight militancy. During her Jantar Mantar visit earlier this week, Mehbooba said the government's crackdowns on local demonstrators in the past were justified in the context of its fight against militancy. The comments drew swift and sharp backlash from rival political parties, who revived the former chief minister's 2016 remark -- in which she asked if the young protesters who approached the Army posts were there to buy "milk and toffee" -- to accuse her of blatant hypocrisy.

Indian students gather in solidarity at London's Trafalgar Square

The 36-day agitation in New Delhi ended on Saturday with the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as the education minister

LONDON: Hundreds of students gathered at Trafalgar Square in London on Sunday to express solidarity with the student movement in India led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

The 36-day agitation in New Delhi ended on Saturday with the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as the education minister.

The Students Federation of India (SFI) UK had organised the weekend protest, which turned into a "celebration of the victory" of the student movement in India.

It welcomed the resignation of Pradhan as education minister and reiterated its stance in support of educational reforms.

"SFI UK salutes the struggle of the student movement and its success in pushing the education minister to resign," SFI UK said in a statement.

"The fight has been very inspiring and courageous. But it has certainly not yet come to



Indian students stage a solidarity demonstration at Trafalgar Square, in London, Sunday

an end. We continue to grieve for the 21 students who have lost their lives due to the handling of NEET, and of course, the brutal police repression against protestors," it stated.

The large gathering at one of London's most iconic squares waved the Indian national flag and placards reading "Ban NEET" and "Diaspora stands with people's resistance". The crowds chanted slogans

of 'Azadi' and sang songs such as 'Yeh Subah Kabhi To Aayegi' and Tagore's 'Ekla Chalo Re'.

"All the international students gathered here, please organise around these issues in your campuses," said one SFI UK worker.

"In the last couple of years, we have seen a rise in the number of Indian students coming here to study in the UK. These are students who are

Key Points

» The Students Federation of India (SFI) UK had organised the weekend protest, which turned into a "celebration of the victory" of the student movement in India

» The crowds chanted slogans of "Azadi" and sang songs such as 'Yeh Subah Kabhi To Aayegi' and Tagore's 'Ekla Chalo Re'

taking massive loans to study here because our country cannot provide them the education that they need or the job opportunities that they need," the worker added.

Similar SFI UK-led demonstrations were planned in other cities, such as Leeds and Liverpool in England, and followed similar protests held in solidarity with the CJP agitation in New Delhi.

TALKS WITH PAKISTAN ONLY ON POK: RAJNATH

Nation salutes Kargil war heroes on Vijay Diwas

MPOST BUREAU

DRAS/NEW DELHI: India on Sunday recalled the valour of the armed forces in the 1999 Kargil war with Defence Minister Rajnath Singh criticising Pakistan for making terrorism a “part of its state policy”, saying there will be no talks with the country other than on PoK.

President Droupadi Murmu, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, chief ministers and leaders across the political spectrum paid tributes to the soldiers who laid down their lives during the war. Events were organised across states and at the Kargil War Memorial in Dras, Ladakh to mark the 27th Kargil Vijay Diwas.

President Murmu paid tribute to the valiant warriors and said the nation shall forever remain indebted to them. “Their unparalleled valour, unwavering resolve, and unparalleled patriotism stand as exemplary models of our army’s glorious traditions,” she said in



Defence minister Rajnath Singh pays tributes to the fallen soldiers on the 27th Kargil Vijay Diwas, at Drass, in Ladakh, on Sunday PTI

a post on X in Hindi. Prime Minister Modi said the valour of India’s brave soldiers in the face of most formidable conditions will forever remain a source of national pride. “Their valour in the face of the most formidable conditions will forever remain a source of national pride. Their unwavering patriotism and devotion to duty will continue to inspire generations,” he said in a post on X.

The Prime Minister said there are certain days in people’s lives that do not require

a calendar to be remembered. “Today, the 26th of July, is one such date. Today is ‘Kargil Vijay Diwas’. This day fills us with pride. This day reminds us of the extraordinary courage of our brave soldiers,” he said while addressing his monthly radio broadcast ‘Mann Ki Baat’.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah said Kargil Vijay Diwas is a symbol of the indomitable valour of the Indian Army. “In 1999, despite the harsh conditions and the enemy’s positions on high-altitude fronts on the formidable snowy peaks of the

KEY POINTS

- » Prez Murmu, PM Modi, CMs and leaders across the political spectrum paid tributes to the soldiers who laid down their lives during the war
- » PM Modi said the valour of brave soldiers will forever remain a source of national pride

Himalayas, our brave soldiers brought the enemy to its knees through ‘Operation Vijay’, he said in a post in Hindi on X.

Defence Minister Singh slammed Pakistan and said there will be no talks with the country other than on Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, which is a “part of India illegally occupied” by it.

In his address at the Kargil War Memorial in Dras, he also said that Operation Sindoor clearly demonstrated what will be the fate of those who attempt to threaten India with terror-

ism, asserting that the country can respond to any misadventure by Pakistan in a manner “beyond their imagination”.

Singh described India’s victory in the Kargil war as “a diamond studded in the crown of Bharat Mata”. Recalling the Operation Sindoor conducted in May 2025 in response to the Pahalgam terror attack, he said, “Any evil step towards the sovereignty and integrity of India will meet with the same fate.”

Singh said at a time when India is designing ships, Pakistan is busy engaging in terror design.

Kargil Vijay Diwas commemorates the culmination of Operation Vijay, the name given to India’s military operation to reclaim the heights of Kargil after Pakistan’s infiltration, which culminated in this day in 1999.

Earlier, Singh, Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth, Ladakh Lieutenant Governor V K Saxena, and the General Officer Commanding-in-Chief, North-

ern Command, Lt Gen Pratik Sharma, paid tribute at the Kargil War Memorial.

Meanwhile, the family of Indian Army soldier Avnish Yadav who laid down his life in the Kargil war, claimed that several promises made by the authorities in recognition of his sacrifice are yet to be fulfilled. Avnish Yadav’s parents are natives of Dalel Tola village in Sitabdiara on the Uttar Pradesh-Bihar border.

His mother, Somaro Devi, said that despite the passage of 26 years, neither has a statue of the martyr been installed nor a government hospital or a primary school have been named after him, as was promised.

His father Shivji Yadav, who retired from the CRPF, said Avnish gave the supreme sacrifice after neutralising 20 Pakistani soldiers.

While the government allotted a petrol pump to Avnish’s widow, other assurances made to the family and the village remain unfulfilled, they said.

Assam floods ease; 6.5L still ‘affected’

Water levels recede in most parts



Children wade through a waterlogged road in Guwahati on Saturday PTI

MPOST BUREAU

GUWAHATI: The flood situation in Assam improved on Sunday as water levels were receding in most of the affected areas with those places not receiving overnight rainfall, even as over 6.5 lakh people remained hit in six districts and 66 people lost their lives in this year’s deluge, officials said.

An official of the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) said that water levels were receding in most of the flood-hit areas of Upper Assam, especially Charaideo, Sivasagar and Jorhat districts.

“We hope the situation would improve further during the day. This would help us provide relief in a better way,” he added.

According to the authority’s daily flood report issued at midnight, more than 6,54,800 people have been affected in Charaideo, Dibrugarh, Golaghat, Jorhat, Nagaon and Sivasagar districts.

Sivasagar was the worst-hit district with nearly 2.7 lakh people affected, followed by Charaideo (1.9 lakh) and Jorhat (1.3 lakh). The flood situation has improved marginally since Friday, when more than 7.05 lakh people were affected across nine districts.

The ASDMA’s midnight bulletin said that four more people lost their lives in the deluge in the last 24 hours, taking the toll in this year’s

floods to 66. Three deaths were reported in Sivasagar and one in Charaideo.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday offered full support to the Assam government in dealing with the deluge, which has shown signs of improvement as rain has stopped in most parts of the state.

Union Ports, Shipping and Waterways Minister Sarbananda Sonowal reviewed the relief measures at camps in flood-affected areas and directed officials concerned to ensure uninterrupted access to healthcare, food, drinking water and other essential services.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the situation has slightly improved and the administration has been able to reach out to almost all the affected areas.

Addressing a press conference after a late-evening cabinet meeting, he said that a central team has arrived in the state to assess the damage caused by the flood in Upper Assam.

ASDMA said the administration has been operating 274 relief camps and distribution centres in six districts, taking care of 18,902 displaced people at present.

Multiple agencies such as the Army, NDRF, SDRF, Fire & Emergency Services, police and civil agencies have rescued many people from different parts of Upper Assam, it added.

DGMA ADVISES INDIAN SEAFARERS

‘Assess security situation before taking up jobs in conflict zones’

NEW DELHI: The Directorate General of Maritime Administration (DGMA) has advised all Indian-flagged and foreign vessels with Indian seafarers to exercise the highest degree of caution while operating in the Black Sea and undertake voyage-specific security risk assessments before entering the affected region.

The advisory came days after five Indians were killed in attacks on two commercial vessels in the Black Sea region in the last week.

“In view of the continuing armed conflicts in the Black Sea and the recent increase in attacks on merchant vessels... all Indian flagged vessels and foreign vessels with Indian sea-

The advisory came days after 5 Indians were killed in attacks on 2 commercial vessels in Black Sea

farers are advised to exercise the highest degree of caution while operating in the Black Sea and undertake voyage-specific security risk assessment before entering the affected region,” DGMA said in a circular on Saturday.

The shipping regulator advised Indian seafarers to continuously monitor and comply with advisories issued by this Directorate or other govern-

ment departments.

Since April 2026, there have been ten such attacks involving Indian seafarers onboard foreign flag ships.

Particular attention is invited to the attack on MV GOLDEN LEO on July 19, 2026, while departing the Port of Odesa, Ukraine, wherein the vessel was struck by multiple missiles. The vessel had five Indian seafarers onboard. The incident resulted in ten casualties, of whom four Indians are presumed dead.

Also, DGMA said the recent attack on flagged tankers MT Asia, MT Louise-1, and MT Nelsa near Novorossiysk, Russia, resulted in damage to the vessels.

Haryana CM flags off anti-drug youth marathon in Yamunanagar

YAMUNANAGAR: Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday flagged off an anti-drug youth marathon here, and called it not just a campaign against drugs, but a collective resolve to build a healthy, safe and empowered Haryana.

The energy, awareness and participation of the youth are the greatest strength in this war against drugs, Saini said in his address.

“When the youth move forward carrying the message of staying away from addiction and embrace a healthy lifestyle, a new consciousness of positive change permeates society. Let us all come together to transform the resolve for a drug-free Haryana into a people’s movement and build a healthy, safe and bright future for the com-

ing generations,” he said.

“If the younger generation remains healthy, disciplined and free from drugs, the dream of building a Viksit Bharat will undoubtedly be realised,” he added.

Flagging off the ‘Nasha Se Jung - Yamunanagar Ke Sang anti-drug run, the Chief Minister administered a pledge to the participants to stay away from drugs and urged them to become ambassadors of a drug-free society. He also said that the fight against drugs is not just the government’s battle, but a fight for the entire society.

The BJP government has transformed public awareness campaigns like ‘Haryana Uday’ into massive public movements against drug abuse, he claimed. “Let us all pledge together

to build a healthy and drug-free Haryana, and a developed India,” he said.

A large number of youth, including students and citizens participated in the marathon.

Stating that every young person stands at the crossroads of two paths – one leading towards life and the other towards addiction, he said, “One path builds the future, while the other destroys it. I am confident that the youth of Haryana, particularly those of Yamunanagar, will choose the path of development, fitness and a bright future.”

Highlighting the importance of fitness, Saini said Prime Minister Narendra Modi had launched the Fit India Movement to encourage a healthy lifestyle.

SENIOR IPS OFFICERS AT THE HELM

UP reconstitutes SIT in Ram Mandir theft probe

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has reconstituted the Special Investigation Team probing the alleged theft and misappropriation of devotees’ donations at the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple in Ayodhya, appointing three senior IPS officers to lead the investigation in line with directions issued by the Supreme Court.

The new SIT will be headed by Inspector General of Police Kiran S. Its other members are DIG Ayodhya Somen Verma and Ayodhya SSP Dr Gaurav Grover. The IPS-led panel replaces the earlier SIT headed by a senior IAS officer and is expected to submit its first sta-

The reconstituted SIT will be required to file periodic status reports before the SC

tus report before the Supreme Court on July 27.

The reconstitution follows the apex court’s direction that the ongoing probe be placed under the supervision of a senior IPS officer to ensure an independent and comprehensive investigation into allegations of embezzlement of cash donations and administrative lapses in the temple’s donation counting process.

While hearing the matter

earlier this week, the Supreme Court said the case should not be politicised and emphasised that it was a straightforward criminal investigation requiring a fair and impartial probe.

Unlike the previous arrangement, the reconstituted SIT will be required to file periodic status reports before the apex court, which has decided to monitor the investigation itself.

The court has ordered an independent and comprehensive probe into allegations of missing donation funds, financial irregularities and administrative lapses in the counting and accounting of offerings made by devotees at the Ram Temple.

A senior police officer said

the state government restructured the SIT after receiving fresh directions from the Supreme Court.

“The court wanted the investigation to be led by senior police officers. Accordingly, the Inspector General of Police, Lucknow Range, has been made the head of the SIT, while the DIG and SSP of Ayodhya have been appointed as its members,” the officer said.

The allegations relate to the handling of offerings made by devotees at the Ram Temple. Investigators are examining claims of missing cash and valuables, suspected manipulation of records and violations of the standard operating procedures governing the counting and accounting of donations.

CISF seizes 1,277 MT ‘illegal’ coal in a week



NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) has intensified its crackdown on illegal coal mining, theft and unauthorised transportation, seizing more than 1,277 metric tonnes (MT) of illegal coal during week-long operations from July 20 to 26.

The operations were conducted under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957 (MMDR Act), as part of the Ministry of Home Affairs’ “Zero Coal Leakage” campaign.

According to the CISF, 85 intelligence-based raids were conducted in coalfields under its security cover. The operations led to the seizure of 1,277 MT of illegal coal, registration of one FIR, arrest of five persons and impounding of 40 vehicles.

The largest recovery, 771 MT, was made from BCCL, Dhanbad, during 14 raids, in which two persons were arrested and one vehicle impounded. At ECL, Sheetalpur, 51 raids resulted in the recovery of 341 MT of coal and seizure of 34 vehicles. Eleven raids in CCL, Kargali, yielded 145 MT.

At NK Piparwar, six raids led to the recovery of 20 MT, registration of an FIR and seizure of three vehicles. In SECL, Bilaspur, three persons were arrested and two vehicles impounded during three raids.

The CISF said intelligence-led operations, technological surveillance, field action and legal powers under the MMDR Act contributed to the results. It said the drive would continue with coal companies, local administration and other agencies.

Saini inaugurates ‘Antyodaya Mela’

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday inaugurated the ‘Antyodaya Mela’ under the Mukhya Mantri Antyodaya Parivar Uthhan Yojana in Ladwa.

Speaking on the occasion, Saini said such events are being organised throughout the state and beneficiaries are being provided the benefits of 47 welfare schemes of 19 departments at a single platform.

At Ladwa, he visited various departmental stalls set up to facilitate the delivery of government schemes and services.

Saini said the ‘Antyodaya Mela’ is a living embodiment of the government’s resolve that every scheme, every resource and every effort should benefit the last person standing in the queue.

He added that Antyodaya



is not merely a government programme but a reflection of India’s civilisational ethos, which envisions that everyone should be happy, healthy and free from suffering.

“Our resolve is clear: no poor person will be left behind, no needy citizen will be deprived of opportunities, and no family will be prevented from progressing merely because it lacks resources,” he said. Saini said that the objective of the Yojana is not merely to provide financial assistance

but to connect every deserving family with sustainable livelihood opportunities.

By bringing schemes related to self-employment, skill development, employment, financial inclusion and social welfare under one roof, eligible families are provided opportunities according to their needs and capabilities. Highlighting the progress achieved under the first phase of the Yojana, the chief minister said that 166 ‘Antyodaya Melas’ have been organised across Haryana so far. He informed that 4,24,278 families were invited to these melas, of which 1,88,792 families attended. Out of these, 1,52,157 families were referred to the departments concerned for further assistance, while 55,422 eligible beneficiaries have already been provided livelihood-related benefits.

MPBDC drives smart construction with AI, BIM and sustainable technologies

Corporation adopts digital engineering, precast systems and sustainable construction to build faster, greener and smarter public infrastructure

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh Building Development Corporation (MPBDC) is embracing emerging technologies such as Artificial Intelligence, Building Information Modelling (BIM), 3D printing and precast construction to transform the way public infrastructure is planned, executed and monitored.

In an interaction with Millennium Post, Managing Director of the MPBDC, Sibi Chakravathy, a 2008 batch IAS officer, said the corporation is working to position Madhya Pradesh at the forefront of sustainable and technology-driven infrastructure development by integrating innovation with environmental responsibility.

“We are not merely constructing buildings; we are creating future-ready infrastructure that is efficient, sustainable and digitally managed throughout its lifecycle,” he said. Chakravathy said that among the key initiatives



MPBDC MD Sibi Chakravathy

being pursued by MPBDC is the exploration of 3D printing technology for construction. Following a detailed study at IIT Madras, the corporation is assessing the feasibility of deploying the technology in upcoming projects to reduce construction time, improve quality and enhance resource efficiency. The corporation is also scaling up the use of precast construction systems, which allow building components to be manufactured in controlled environments and assembled on-site. The technology is expected to signifi-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » 3D printing technology under evaluation
- » Precast systems to accelerate construction
- » BIM enables real-time project monitoring
- » AI-powered, paperless project management

cantly shorten project timelines while maintaining higher quality standards, the MD said.

A major pillar of MPBDC’s innovation strategy is the adoption of Building Information Modelling. BIM has been implemented across projects to enable real-time monitoring of physical and financial progress, design coordination, project delays and other critical parameters, he added.

According to him, digitalisation has fundamentally changed the corporation’s functioning. Processes ranging from Detailed Project Reports

(DPRs) and technical approvals to billing, electronic measurement books and extension-of-time approvals have been integrated into a digital workflow, reducing paperwork and improving efficiency.

“The corporation has also introduced AI-enabled camera monitoring through its Project Management System (PMS), allowing continuous surveillance of construction activities and strengthening quality control mechanisms,” Chakravathy said. “The PMS has helped create a largely paperless and fileless work environment, enhancing transparency and accountability in project execution,” he further added.

Sustainability remains a central focus of MPBDC’s infrastructure strategy. Several projects undertaken by the corporation are being developed in accordance with GRIHA and Indian Green Building Council standards, with many securing 3-Star, 4-Star and 5-Star green building ratings.

Varanasi: Egg, meat, fish sale banned along Kanwar routes

VARANASI: Sale of meat, fish and eggs will remain prohibited along designated Kanwar routes in Varanasi throughout Sawan, as the Uttar Pradesh Food Safety and Drug Administration has launched a special enforcement drive to ensure safe and hygienic food for devotees visiting the Kashi Vishwanath Temple.

Sawan begins on July 30, with the first Monday falling on August 3. Food outlets within three km of the Kashi Vishwanath Temple and other major Shiva temples have been directed to prominently display valid licences or registration certificates and price lists.

Inspection teams are checking eateries and food stalls along major Kanwar routes from Kachhwa to Rohania, Laxa and the temple. Operators have been asked to maintain cleanliness and keep food covered.

Assistant Commissioner, Food Safety, Kaushalendra Sharma said inspections would continue throughout Sawan. Violators may face monetary penalties and legal action.



EDITORIAL
WEIGHT OF
LONGEVITY

Mirabai Chanu's fourth consecutive Commonwealth Games medal, and her third successive gold, is not merely another addition to India's medal tally. It is a reminder that sustained excellence in elite sport is far rarer than spectacular success. Modern sport celebrates breakthrough performances and record-breaking feats, but it often overlooks the extraordinary discipline required to remain relevant over a decade. Between her silver medal in Glasgow in 2014 and her latest triumph in the same city twelve years later, Chanu has navigated Olympic heart-break, world championship glory, injuries, changing weight categories and the relentless physical demands of weightlifting. Her victory in Glasgow was expected, perhaps even inevitable, yet therein lies its significance. Dominance should never be mistaken for routine. Every medal won after years at the top represents not simply superior talent but an athlete's ability to constantly reinvent herself. At a time when Indian sport is producing more champions than ever before, Mirabai's career stands out because it has been built not on isolated moments of brilliance but on consistency, resilience and intelligent planning.

What made Glasgow 2026 particularly noteworthy was not the weight she lifted but the weight she deliberately chose not to lift. Unlike the ambitious youngster of 2014 or the redemption-seeking champion of 2018, Chanu approached these Commonwealth Games with remarkable strategic clarity. She resisted chasing symbolic milestones and instead treated the competition as preparation for the far more demanding Asian Games. That shift reflects the evolution of Indian high-performance sport itself. Elite athletes today understand that careers are no longer measured by individual competitions but by carefully managed Olympic and continental cycles. Peak performance is increasingly a matter of sports science, recovery, nutrition, injury prevention and workload management as much as raw strength. Chanu's measured campaign demonstrates the maturity of an athlete who knows that success sometimes depends as much on restraint as on aggression. It also reflects the growing sophistication of India's sporting ecosystem, where athletes and coaches are beginning to prioritise long-term performance over short-term applause. This cultural change is essential if India is to become a consistently successful sporting nation rather than one that celebrates occasional heroes.

Yet Chanu's success also highlights an uncomfortable reality. More than a decade after she emerged as India's leading weightlifter, the country still relies disproportionately on the same champion to deliver medals at major competitions. The Commonwealth Games have repeatedly exposed the gap between India's elite performers and the depth of its sporting pipeline. While India has made considerable progress in identifying talent through initiatives such as the Target Olympic Podium Scheme, Khelo India and greater private-sector support, succession planning remains uneven across many Olympic disciplines. Weightlifting, in particular, has struggled to produce athletes capable of consistently challenging the world's best beyond a handful of exceptional individuals. This dependence is risky, especially in a physically demanding sport where injuries and age inevitably reshape careers. Countries that dominate Olympic sport do so because they build systems rather than personalities. India's long-term ambition must therefore move beyond celebrating champions like Chanu and focus equally on creating the next generation of lifters through scientific coaching, grassroots competitions, stronger state federations, anti-doping vigilance and world-class training infrastructure. Sporting greatness becomes sustainable only when excellence is institutional rather than individual.

For Mirabai Chanu herself, the Commonwealth Games are no longer the destination; they are a milestone along a larger journey. The Asian Games remain one of the few major honours missing from an otherwise glittering résumé that already includes an Olympic silver medal, a world championship title and three Commonwealth Games gold medals. That objective explains the calculated approach she adopted in Glasgow. It also offers a lesson that extends beyond sport. True champions understand that every victory must serve a larger purpose. They resist the temptation to pursue every record and instead conserve energy for the contests that matter most. Chanu's latest triumph is therefore not simply a story of another gold medal. It is the story of an athlete who has mastered perhaps the hardest skill in elite sport: staying hungry after success, adapting without losing ambition, and recognising that longevity is itself a measure of greatness. As India prepares for the Asian Games and, beyond that, the Los Angeles Olympics, Mirabai Chanu remains more than a champion weightlifter. She represents the standard of professionalism, patience and perseverance that Indian sport must seek to replicate across every discipline.

PUBLIC
SQUARE



ANIRBAN GANGULY

THE WRITER IS A MEMBER OF THE NATIONAL EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE (NEC), BJP, AND THE CHAIRMAN OF DR SYAMA PRASAD MOOKERJEE RESEARCH FOUNDATION

The Congress's response to the examination crisis raises a larger question: is the principal Opposition seeking institutional reform through Parliament, or political recovery through disruption on the streets?

GLOBAL
LENS



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT, AND A FORMER NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISOR IN MAURITIUS

16 agreements, a BrahMos deal, critical minerals cooperation, maritime connectivity through Sabang, and expanding trade underline the growing strategic convergence between Asia's two largest democracies

Congress' Anarchy System

Rajni Kothari once traced the decline of the "Congress system". Today, the party's critics argue that its politics is moving from parliamentary contestation towards street mobilisation and institutional confrontation

25 years ago, political scientist and public intellectual Rajni Kothari spoke of the decline of the "Congress system." Kothari spoke of the Congress becoming a "caricature of the Congress system", in many ways a negation of it. He had famously coined the term "Congress System." Kothari referred to the Congress's "long-term decline starting from 1967 and continuing since..." The Congress, he concluded, was facing a kind of "nemesis."

In the course of its long-term decline, the Congress lit fires and flashpoints across the country. From Kashmir to Tamil Nadu, to the northeast, the Congress system in decline left political, social, linguistic, caste, denominational and governance issues and challenges unattended. Often it has complicated situations and problems. It served the Congress's politics to keep pots boiling and wounds festering. It was its way of deriving political mileage and capital.

Indira was dismissive of Parliament. She avoided serious discussion and was often impatient with its procedures and functioning. Rajiv, with his brute majority, often rammed through legislation detrimental to national health. The Shah Bano episode was one of the most glaring such instances. No one during Indira and Rajiv's tenure spoke of "electoral autocracy". Most of those who speak of an "electoral autocracy" in India today, were beneficiaries of the Congress system and were heavily co-opted by it. They continue to be loyal to it.

The long-term decline of the Congress continues to this day. Kothari's erstwhile intellectual disciples, such as Yogendra Yadav, who have now emerged as one of the principal advisors of the Congress, are ensuring that the Congress's long-term decline turns into a terminal decline.

From the "Congress system", the likes of Yadav have now proposed an anarchy system, in which Parliament and Parliamentary democracy, electoral democracy, and elections become irrelevant. They seem to be proposing that matters of the Republic and of governance be decided on the streets and through street-fights.

Referring to Parliament as a "pigsty" was once a favourite pastime of Communists the world over. Indian communists reluctantly took to Parliamentary politics so that they could survive and keep aloof. Their fundamental ideological disdain for electoral and Parliamentary democracy, however, remained unchanged.

The CPI (Maoist)'s subversive strategies once spoke of dismantling the Parliamentary system and of overthrowing the Constitutional and democratic structure of India. There seems to be a convergence of such destructionist ideologies in the



The once-mainstream Congress is veering towards the fringe, increasingly seeking to settle political questions on the streets rather than through Parliament

approach and style of the Congress's politics today. The once mainstream Congress is veering to the fringe. It wants all issues to be settled on the streets and not in and through Parliament. The Congress is trying to reincarnate itself as a combined platform for the votaries of overthrowing parliamentary democracy.

This comes across as a worrying sign. Worrying because the Congress's pre-eminent agenda of removing Narendra Modi from power, does not hinge on the norms and structures of an electoral democracy. The Congress is seen to be increasingly trying to take recourse to the tactics of the putsch. Despite having the position of the Leader of Opposition, it displays disdain for Parliament and encourages and supports un-Parliamentary politics. Its support of anarchists who have infiltrated the students' protest in Delhi and are trying to take control of it, reflects that disdain.

With their political capital fast depleting, the Congress depends on the fringe to bail it out. Its concern for students is just an alibi. It is a camouflage for their politics of wrecking Parliamentary democracy. The Congress has still not been able to recover from its defeat of 2014 and from its failure to unseat Modi in 2024. It has dumped and abjured all decency in its conduct; otherwise it would not have held a flash protest at the doorstep of the official residence of the Prime Minister of India, an act unheard of in the annals of free India's democracy.

Students have always been a dispensable commodity for the Congress. The decade between 2004 and 2014 was plagued with repeated paper leaks, with several major national examinations, including the AIPGMEE (All India Post Graduate Medical Entrance Examination), AIEEE (All India Engineering Entrance Examination), and CBSE Board

examinations being compromised. Congress paid no attention to these systemic failures, and instead allowed the examinations to continue, while limiting the investigations. No comprehensive legal or legislative framework was put in place to address the rot. Just as in defence deals, the Congress it appeared to many, seems to have fingers in a number of paper leak cases and rackets as well.

A dig into the near past reveals how over 100 pan-India examination leaks occurred in the heydays of the Congress and its allied parties. Starting with the Armed Forces Medical College examination (AFMC) paper in 1972 to the Railway Recruitment Examination of 2013. In state after state, ruled by the Congress in the past, paper leaks had become normalised. The list of paper leaks, all pointing to the Congress' failure or complicity, as one takes it, is a long one.

Despite being urged to, despite the issue being repeatedly taken up, the Congress did nothing to stem this disease. Examination paper leaks were also routine in states ruled by parties allied to the Congress or later, part of the INDI alliance. The Trinamool Congress's record has been a shocking one. Mamata Banerjee's government presided over the WBSSC Teachers Recruitment (SSC Scam) which saw 26,000 families affected and hundreds of crores being amassed by the party's top leadership. Her TMC continues to be a valued ally of the Congress. The Congress and its allies had kept silent on that devastating issue. They signalled support to the TMC.

The UPAs failed decade 2004-2014, saw no central law or agency being introduced. A dedicated central anti-paper-leak statute was absent; no national testing agency was set up. The elaborate and fine-tuned monitoring system that has been put in place today by the Modi

Government, was absent or ignored during the Congress decade. A detailed debate in Parliament today on the issue will also expose the Congress's apathy over decades in trying to fix this national challenge.

In line with his pledge to plug loopholes and to usher in systemic cleaning, PM Modi established the National Testing Agency in 2017. It was further restructured in 2025 into focusing only on entrance examinations for higher education institutions. In 2024, Parliament enacted the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act. It was India's first dedicated law against paper leaks and organised cheating. The provisions were stringent, with imprisonment and fines upto Rs 1 crore for those who traded future of students. What prevented the Congress from bringing such legislation in its fifty years of running India? What prevented the Left parties, with their so-called sense of social justice, from forcing the UPA from introducing legislation to address the challenge.

Concern over medical entrance examinations in 2024 saw the Modi Government form an empowered committee headed by one of India's most respected scientists K Radhakrishnan. The K Radhakrishnan Committee recommended deeper and more fundamental reforms such as stricter accountability mechanisms for examination functionaries, SOP for the secure and safe transportation and custody of question papers, improved grading and monitoring of examination centres, a stronger district-level coordination, facial biometric authentication and live photography.

Widening the enforcement net, action was swift on the conspirators of the leak. The case was handed over to the CBI, registering an FIR; a multi-state raid led to the arrest of 13 people, including a doctor and a coaching-institute faculty who were identified as the kingpins. 24 key suspects were also handed over to the central agencies, and the investigation remains live. From next year, the tests are set to be held in the Computer Based Test (CBT) mode. PM Modi's announcing the fast-track courts and further strengthening the anti-paper leak law are the latest measures in a long series, aimed at decisively and comprehensively addressing this challenge.

The Congress and the proponents of the "Anarchy-System" do not actually want an enduring rectification of the flawed system. They do not intend to discuss India's educational scenario in Parliament. They want, instead, to brawl out issues that concern India's future and her youth, on the streets. They want to lay the first bricks of the "Anarchy-System." That attempt must be exposed and opposed.

Views expressed are personal

A Strategic Maritime Partnership

PM Modi's July 2026 visit to Indonesia produced landmark agreements in defence, critical minerals, maritime connectivity and trade, signalling a deeper strategic partnership in the Indo-Pacific

In a bold new move, India has reached out to Indonesia to bolster the existing strategic ties between the two countries. Several significant pacts were inked during Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi's visit to Indonesia (July 6 to 8, 2026). Strategists reckon that Modi's visit significantly deepens the India-Indonesia strategic partnership. The two largest Asian democracies signed 16 agreements covering a varied gamut of areas, including defence, critical minerals, maritime connectivity, trade, education, health, and culture. Among the major defence and economic breakthroughs, Indonesia will now acquire BrahMos super-sonic cruise missiles (~US\$630 million) and Astra air-to-air missiles. New deals also focus on critical minerals, steel joint ventures, and port development linking Sabang (Aceh) with India's Andaman & Nicobar Islands to enhance maritime security and trade. This is seen as a major step forward in the strategic ties between the two countries. Significantly, in the cultural field, Indonesia awarded Modi its highest civilian honour (Bintang Adipurna). PM Modi addressed the Parliament and visited the Prambanan Temple (with India pledging renovation assistance), while both sides further aim to boost bilateral trade from US\$23.2 billion to much higher levels in the coming years.

It is also worth mentioning that India and Indonesia share two thousand years of civilisational links. They are maritime neighbours, close friends, comprehensive strategic partners, and Asia's largest democracies. Though it was not his first visit to Indonesia, PM Modi, this time,



Stronger India-Indonesia ties are expected to enhance regional stability

received a tumultuous welcome marked by greater affection, closeness, and respect. Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto, who is a close friend of Modi, personally received him at the airport and gave him a warm send-off upon his departure. This signals the natural warmth between the two leaders and their nations.

Touching upon the defence agreement, the BrahMos procurement represents a major milestone in Indonesia's long-standing effort to strengthen its coastal defence capabilities. While details of the contract's value and delivery schedule have not yet been disclosed, the agreement transitions years of preliminary talks into an official pact. The Reuters news agency reported that the deal is estimated to be worth around US\$630 million.

In a simultaneous push for aerial modernisation, state-owned Indian defence manufacturer Bharat Dynamics Limited (BDL) signed a cooperation agreement with Indonesia's Republikorp for the procurement of Astra air-to-air missiles (AAMs). Speaking at the Merdeka Presidential Palace,

PM Modi said the agreements reflect a shared geopolitical vision to secure critical maritime security interests.

On his part, President Prabowo also underscored the importance of strengthening the Indonesia-India Security Dialogue, as both countries face evolving regional security challenges and unconventional threats. "As the challenges posed by transnational security issues increase, both countries are now committed to deepening capacity development in modern and advanced technologies, combating transnational crime, and developing digital infrastructure," according to President Prabowo.

Also, according to the Jakarta Globe news website, three out of the dozen Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) signed following Modi's talks with President Prabowo Subianto were related to critical minerals. One document focused on cooperation in "minerals and technologies for the steel supply chain." Steel Authority of India and Krakatau Steel—both state-owned entities—also agreed to set up a joint venture of

an undisclosed value. There was also an MoU between the Non-Ferrous Materials Technology Development Centre (NFTDC), Midwest, and the nascent Perusahaan Mineral Nasional. Prabowo, on his part, made no direct mention of the steel deal but described "economic ties as a key pillar of bilateral relations." To this end, Indonesia hopes to hasten negotiations on a Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA) with India, according to Prabowo. A PTA typically enables lower tariffs on certain goods. It also deserves mention that Indonesia commands the world's largest reserves of nickel, the silvery-white metal crucial to steel production, amounting to a whopping 62 million metric tons. Jakarta, however, has stopped exporting raw nickel ore and is restricting shipments to processed products for greater economic gains.

In another development, it merits reiteration that President Prabowo Subianto reaffirmed Indonesia's commitment to strengthening maritime connectivity with India through the joint development of strategic ports in Sabang, Aceh, and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. Speaking during a joint press statement with Modi at the Merdeka Palace in Jakarta on July 7, Prabowo said the two ports would serve as a strategic maritime link to deepen economic cooperation and strengthen bilateral relations between the two countries. He also expressed hope that stronger maritime connectivity would facilitate trade and investment, improve logistics, and promote greater people-to-people exchanges through enhanced regional mobility. He emphasised that Indonesia and India view eco-

nommic cooperation as one of the key pillars of their bilateral partnership. He said both countries remain committed to expanding collaboration across various strategic sectors to generate tangible benefits for their peoples. At the same time, he expressed hope that the development of the maritime corridor would become a concrete step towards strengthening the Indonesia-India strategic partnership and enhancing cooperation across the broader Indo-Pacific region. Geographically, Sabang, located on Weh Island in Aceh, lies about 700 kilometres southeast of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and approximately 160 kilometres from India's Great Nicobar Project.

Both locations overlook the northern entrance to the Strait of Malacca, one of the world's busiest maritime chokepoints, through which a substantial share of global trade and energy shipments passes.

Importantly, Indonesia and India are also pursuing efforts to establish direct shipping routes between Sabang and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands while expanding cooperation in fisheries, rare earth minerals, and regional trade. It may be recalled that bilateral trade between Indonesia and India stood at US\$23.2 billion in 2025. India is a major buyer of Indonesia's leading products, including coal, palm oil, rubber, paper, and spices. There is significant potential for bilateral trade to reach US\$550 billion over the next 10 years. Independent analysts believe that Modi's visit to Indonesia was a major success, as it further strengthened the existing strategic ties between the two countries.

Views expressed are personal

'A PAUSE IN US AND IRANIAN STRIKES IS A POSITIVE SIGNAL'

US pauses attacks on Iran for 2nd straight day, Tehran does too

CAIRO: The United States paused its attacks on Iran for a second straight day Sunday and Tehran said it had done so too, as efforts continued to bring the countries back to negotiations on an interim ceasefire deal largely undermined by recent exchanges of fire.

It was not clear why the US has paused after targeting Iranian coastal areas and infrastructure in a nearly two-week escalation sparked by Iran's firing at ships trying to transit the Strait of Hormuz. The Pentagon did not immediately respond to questions Sunday.

"President (Donald) Trump has always been consistent in saying he prefers a diplomatic solution, but he continues to retain all options if Iran continues terrorist activities in the Strait of Hormuz or against allies," White House communications director Steven Cheung said, adding: "It would be wise for Iran to work toward a negotiated deal. Otherwise, they know what will happen."



President Donald Trump

Since the US has halted attacks for the past two nights, Iran has as well, its army spokesperson told Iran's state TV on Sunday. Tehran in recent days has counter-attacked against countries in the region hosting US military forces, killing at least three at a base in Jordan.

The 60-day period that began when the interim deal was signed by both countries

in mid-June is now well into its second half, and major issues that were meant to be negotiated -- notably Iran's nuclear program at the heart of tensions -- remain set aside as mediators try to keep both sides talking.

A regional official involved in mediation efforts said diplomacy was underway and that a pause in US and Iranian strikes was a "positive signal that helps

“IT WOULD BE WISE FOR IRAN TO WORK TOWARD A NEGOTIATED DEAL. OTHERWISE, THEY KNOW WHAT WILL HAPPEN”

their efforts to de-escalate.”

The official said both countries want to return to the interim ceasefire deal and that a compromise being negotiated centres on having Iran run vessel transit through the Strait of Hormuz with fewer restrictions on ships. The official was not authorised to discuss the matter and spoke on condition of anonymity.

Concerns continued about shipping on the strait and now on another crucial waterway in the region, the Bab al-Mandeb strait to the Red Sea. Iranian-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen last week threatened a blockade

of Saudi shipping there.

Global energy supplies and the economy remain in the balance as gasoline prices have risen again.

Iran on Sunday said it continued to speak with Oman about managing the safe passage of ships on the Strait of Hormuz, which passes between the countries. Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson, Esmail Baghaei, said talks had made progress and continued.

Baghaei also said the strait's status remained unchanged. Tehran has asserted that the interim deal with the US allows it to manage shipping on the waterway for now, and it has objected to US efforts to support a route through the strait that passes close to Oman instead.

The US military on Saturday said its recently reimposed naval blockade against Iran continued, with a dozen commercial ships redirected, two disabled and two boarded. AGENCIES

Houthis fire missiles at Saudi in response to strikes in Yemen

Red Sea escalation further threatens global shipping

CAIRO: Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels said Saturday that they fired missiles and drones at Saudi Arabia in response to Saudi airstrikes on the strategic Red Sea city of Hodeida, in an escalation over vital shipping routes in the Middle East while the United States and Iran vie for control of the Strait of Hormuz.

Brig Gen Yahya Saree, the Houthis' military spokesperson, said in a prerecorded statement that the attack targeted facilities in the Red Sea cities of Yanbu and Jizan that belong to Aramco, the world's largest oil company.

Saudi Arabia's civil defence said alerts sounded multiple times early Saturday in both cities, but the kingdom didn't comment further.

There were no reported strikes overnight in Iran, in an apparent break from nearly two weeks of consecutive nights of US attacks.

The Houthis have said they would close the Bab el-Mandeb Strait to Saudi-linked shipping in retaliation for the kingdom's blockade



Highlights

- » Saudi Arabia's civil defence said alerts sounded multiple times
- » There were no reported strikes overnight in Iran

on Yemen and a recent attack on the international airport in Yemen's rebel-held capital, Sanaa.

"Nothing short of ending the aggression and lifting the blockade, otherwise, it's all illusion and mirage,"

Mahdi al-Mashat, head of the Houthi-led Supreme Political Council governing rebel-controlled territories in Yemen, said of what it would take for the Houthis to not blockade the Bab-El-Mandeb.

That strait, at the southern tip of the Arabian Peninsula, is a vital shipping chokepoint connecting the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden.

Around 12 per cent of the world's trade, including a quarter of its container traffic, passes through the narrows. AGENCIES

NATO intern arrested in Belgium on spying charge at headquarters

BRUSSELS: A Canadian woman was arrested and accused of espionage while working as an intern in the operational headquarters of the NATO military alliance, Belgian authorities said Saturday.

Belgium's Federal Prosecutor's Office said it launched an espionage investigation after NATO's security services tipped off Belgium's military

intelligence. Authorities then detained "a Canadian citizen of Chinese origin" on Friday, a day after raiding the suspect's home and workplace inside NATO's vast command centre.

"She is suspected of spying on behalf of a third country and of being a member of a criminal organisation," the prosecutors said in a statement. AGENCIES

Mosques in West Bank set on fire

The incident occurred during weekend of settler violence

TEL AVIV: Two mosques in the Israeli-occupied West Bank were set on fire overnight in an apparent Israeli settler attack, officials said Sunday, after a spate of deadly violence that killed four Palestinians and two Israeli soldiers.

The violence comes as Palestinians and the Israeli opposition accuse Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's hard-line government of turning a

blind eye to attacks by settlers against Palestinians, which threatens to ignite widespread violence across the territory.

Israeli soldiers and police fanned out across the West Bank after the attack, closing off major roads and blocking access to a hospital where it said two militants were hiding. Israel also arrested more than 70 Palestinians over the weekend as it attempted to contain

the escalating violence.

The mosques in the villages of Qusra and Kour in the northern West Bank suffered extensive damage in the fires. In Qusra, the attackers spray-painted "revenge Benayahu," referring to one of the Israeli soldiers killed on Friday, and "the land of Israel is redeemed with blood." The soldier lived in a nearby settlement.

Ahmed Abu Mahmoud, 64, who lives next door to the Qusra mosque, said he heard noises at 3 am and discovered the mosque had been set on fire.

The fire was too large for him to fight on his own, so he called for help. Mahmoud said livestock and a drinking tank had been stolen in the past month, but that Israeli authorities hadn't helped. AGENCIES

Typhoon Noul makes landfall in southern China; 10 killed



Representational Image

BEIJING: Ten people were killed in rain-triggered floods in China as Typhoon Noul made landfall early Sunday in the southern province of Guangdong.

Noul, the 12th and the strongest typhoon to hit China so far this year, made landfall at Huizhou city in Guangdong around 3:50 am, bringing gale-force winds and heavy rain to large parts of the region.

Rain-triggered flash floods killed 10 in China's Gansu scenic area, state-run Xinhua news agency reported.

China's National Commission for Disaster Prevention, Reduction and Relief activated a Level-IV national disaster relief emergency response for Guangdong.

Level-IV is the least severe tier in the four-tier emergency response system. Level I is the most critical/severe.

High-speed rail services and flights across Guangdong province were cancelled on

Sunday after Typhoon Noul made landfall in the province, bringing heavy rainfall to large parts of southern China.

The National Meteorological Centre issued its first red alert for a typhoon this year on Saturday evening. The alert was downgraded to orange and later to yellow on Sunday as Typhoon Noul weakened.

Red is the highest alert in China's four-tier, colour-coded warning system, in which blue is the lowest level.

The typhoon packed winds of up to 162 kilometres per hour, slightly stronger than Typhoon Bavi, which struck eastern and northeastern China about two weeks ago, the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post reported.

A working team has been dispatched to the affected areas to assess the situation and assist local authorities in relocating and resettling residents, besides ensuring their basic living needs. AGENCIES

France wildfires force nearly 250,000 people to flee

LEGE-CAP-FERRET: A raging wildfire in southwest France forced the evacuation of 55,000 people overnight Sunday, bringing the total forced out of their homes to a staggering 220,000 in one region alone, as flames crept ever closer to the wine region city of Bordeaux. Neighbouring Spain oversaw its own fire evacuations on the country's east coast.

Shifting, gusting winds and arid conditions complicated massive efforts to limit the spread of the monster blaze that has burned out of control since midweek in France's Gironde region, where Bordeaux is located. Authorities issued overnight evacuation orders for five more localities southwest of the historic city.

"The situation remains very unfavourable," French Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said after what he described as "another difficult night" for



Wildfires advance near Le Proge regionap/

PTI

fire crews battling round-the-clock against the blaze that has burned an area four times the size of Paris.

"The fire again became extremely virulent again and unpredictable, generating its own winds and advancing erratically toward the Bordeaux metropolitan area," Nunez posted on X.

"It became calmer by the end of the night," the minister added. At the end of his Sunday Angelus prayer, Pope Leo XIV referenced "the devastating wildfires" in France and Spain and said: "I express my solidarity and invite everyone to pray for those affected and for the work of the rescue workers". AGENCIES

Vessel with 4 Indians struck at Ukraine's port

LONDON: A merchant vessel with four Indians aboard came under attack at Ukraine's Odesa port and two of them are safe, the Indian Embassy in Kyiv said on Sunday.

The information about the other two is still awaited, the mission said.

The incident occurred on Saturday when MV AGN Ragnar was hit at the Port of Odesa, one of Ukraine's key Black Sea ports that has frequently come under attack since the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine conflict in 2022.

The Indian mission, in a statement, said it is closely monitoring the situation.

There was no immediate information on the source of the strike, the circumstances surrounding the incident or the total strength of the vessel's crew.

"Embassy of India in

Two Indians are safe while the information about the other two is still awaited, as per mission

Ukraine is closely monitoring the situation following the incident involving MV AGN Ragnar, which was struck at the Port of Odesa on July 25," it said. Four Indian nationals were on board the vessel at the time of the incident, the embassy said.

"As per the latest information, two have been confirmed safe, and information is awaited regarding the other two nationals," it said.

The identities of the four Indian nationals and the nature of their duties on board were also not immediately known. AGENCIES

Brazil's govt denies visas to US officials over elections

SAO PAULO: Brazil's Foreign Ministry said on Saturday it denied visas to two US State Department officials that sought to travel to the South American nation next week, in the latest political barb between the two countries.

The move became public after The Washington Post reported the Brazilian government saying the officials, Riley M Barnes, an assistant secretary, and Samuel Samson, a deputy assistant, wanted to cast doubt on the upcoming October elections in Brazil.

A spokesperson for Brazil's foreign office said Barnes and Samson requested visas on July 20 and they were denied Friday. AGENCIES

At least 2 dead in Ukraine from Russian attacks

KYIV: Russian ballistic missiles struck Kyiv early on Sunday, setting off fires and wounding at least three civilians, while attacks on other parts of Ukraine later killed at least two people, local officials reported.

The strikes come as Ukraine's successful drone attacks have stalled the Russian army's advances in an expanded campaign inside Russia that has been causing fuel shortages and piling pressure on Russian leader Vladimir Putin.

In Russian-occupied eastern Ukraine, Kremlin-installed authorities said a Ukrainian drone strike had killed four civilians in the city of Horlivka. According to Ivan Prikhodko, the city's Russian-appointed mayor, the city had been under fire since the early hours of Sunday. According to Russia's defence ministry, Russian forces overnight struck down 133 Ukrainian drones over Russia, the Black Sea and Crimea, the peninsula that Moscow forcibly annexed from

Blasts rocked Kyiv in the early hours of Sunday, with falling debris sparking a blaze in a tower block near historic centre

Ukraine in 2014.

Blasts rocked Kyiv in the early hours of Sunday, with falling debris sparking a blaze in a tower block near the historic centre, according to mayor Vitali Klitschko.

Elsewhere in the capital, falling debris set fire to buildings, cars and car parks, Klitschko added. He said three people had been wounded, with one needing hospital treatment.

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy warned in his evening address on Friday that intelligence assessments indicated that Russia was preparing missiles for a large attack. AGENCIES

As Trump boosts nuclear power, regulators seek to eliminate radiation safety rule

NRC Chairman says the commission is not lowering the bar on safety

PROVIDENCE: The Nuclear Regulatory Commission is proposing to eliminate a foundational safety principle that has for 50 years minimised the radiation people in the United States are exposed to and that has been adopted around the world.

Currently, facilities such as nuclear plants, hospitals or academic institutions that use radioactive materials must ensure radiation exposures are kept "as low as reasonably achievable" -- the ALARA principle. The NRC proposal would abandon that philosophy while keeping a separate standard on maximum radiation exposure.

Dose limits set the maximum amount of radiation the public and radiation workers can be exposed to, while ALARA kept radiation exposure as low as practical under those limits. Research shows radiation exposure increases a person's chance of getting cancer, a risk that increases as the dose increases.



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

The dose limits are not changing. But the NRC, which regulates civilian nuclear energy technologies and radioactive materials, now wants to replace ALARA with a "graded approach" that includes several actions facilities must take depending on the potential dose of radiation to workers. More rigorous radiation protection measures would be required when approaching dose limits to ensure they aren't exceeded.

Key Points

- » Reforming the NRC is one way Trump is trying to speed up nuclear reactor development
- » 'Radiation exposure increases a person's chance of getting cancer'

This comes as President Donald Trump attempts to quadruple domestic nuclear energy production because of surging electricity demand amid a data centre and artificial intelligence boom. Reforming the NRC is one way Trump is trying to speed up nuclear reactor development. He instructed the federal agency in an executive order last year to "adopt science-based radiation limits."

The Energy Department, which oversees national

energy policies, has already stopped using ALARA. The NRC expects to finalise its radiation protection regulations in the coming months.

NRC Chairman Ho Nieh said the commission is not lowering the bar on safety.

"We're just removing the ambiguity," he said in a call with reporters. "But the standard for exposure to workers and the public, those are not changing. We're just putting in place greater clarification."

Nieh doesn't expect major changes within the nation's existing fleet of large, traditional reactors. But companies designing and building new, smaller reactors could move faster with a clearer picture of the radiation protection requirements, he said. The NRC said radiation exposure limits are set well below levels associated with health effects, and it expects remaining standards and industry practices to keep radiation doses far below the limits. AGENCIES

World Briefs

PARTNER ARRESTED FOR KILLING INDIAN-ORIGIN WOMAN IN CANADA

OTTAWA: A 22-year-old man, accused of strangling to death his 23-year-old partner -- both Indian-origin -- has been arrested and charged with second-degree murder in western Canada, police said. Ritish Kumar was arrested on July 22 for killing Damanpreet Kaur in Edmonton, capital of Alberta province, in what is described as an intimate partner homicide case, a Canadian Broadcasting Corporation (CBC) report said on Friday. The CBC News quoting a Thursday's statement by Edmonton police said the investigators are not looking for any additional suspects at this time.

B'DESH TO PROBE GRAFT ALLEGATIONS AGAINST EX-PRESIDENT SHAHABUDDIN

DHAKA: Bangladesh's former president Mohammed Shahabuddin, who resigned two days ago, will be probed for alleged corruption allegations, Law Minister Mohammad Asaduzzaman said on Sunday. The 76-year-old, Shahabuddin, a longtime ally of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina, resigned on Friday, citing health complications, two years ahead of the end of his tenure. His resignation comes amid speculations that Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's government was uncomfortable with the largely titular head of the state. "The government does not want to do injustice against any person. But the allegations of corruption before his assumption of presidency are being scrutinised thoroughly," Minister said.

Reforms & infra key to unlock next phase of India’s gas demand growth

India remains heavily dependent on imports to meet LNG & LPG needs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India’s long-term natural gas growth will depend not only on expanding LNG import capacity but also on accelerating investment in transmission and distribution infrastructure, gas-intensive industries, and reforms to market design, regulation and pricing, according to a new report of International Gas Union (IGU). While India has significantly expanded regasification terminal capacity, the pace of investment in midstream infrastructure has lagged, limiting the country’s ability to increase gas consumption. The report argues that reforms to pricing mechanisms and market access will be essential to support sustained growth in gas demand. “The Strait of Hormuz crisis has underlined several import dependencies for India, particularly in gas supply chains. India’s heavy reliance on Gulf-sourced LPGs and LNG, where Qatari exports are the primary source of supply, will bring into question India’s historic reliance on close geographical suppliers that have proven to be vulnerable to disruption. “These issues are not insignificant, and the current price shock will also, in the short term, upend the economics of imported gas for Indian



Domestic gas output meets around 50-52% of the country’s demand, with balance met through imports of LNG, primarily from Qatar, Australia, the US and Russia

power producers, industrial and domestic customers, for as long as it lasts,” it said. India remains heavily dependent on imports to meet its natural gas and LPG requirements. Domestic gas output meets around 50-52 per cent of the country’s demand, with the balance met through imports of liquefied natural gas (LNG), primarily from Qatar, Australia, the US and Russia. The dependence is even more pronounced in liquefied petroleum gas (LPG). India

HIGHLIGHTS

» The dependence is even more pronounced in LPG. India imports around 60-65% of its LPG need despite being one of the world’s largest LPG consumers

» Much of these imports transit from Strait of Hormuz. During Iran war, transit through the strait was disrupted, exposing India’s vulnerability

» International Gas Union said over the longer term, however, the outlook could improve if the Gulf crisis eases

imports around 60-65 per cent of its LPG requirement despite being one of the world’s largest LPG consumers. Much of these imports transit from Strait of Hormuz. During the recent Iran war, energy transit through the strait was disrupted, exposing India’s vulnerability. IGU said over the longer term, however, the outlook could improve if the Gulf crisis eases. A wave of new LNG export capacity expected to come online through the remainder of the decade is likely

to leave global LNG markets well supplied, putting downward pressure on prices and improving the economics of gas consumption in India. Permanent demand destruction elsewhere in Asia following the recent price shock could further accelerate declines in Asian benchmark LNG prices, making greater gas deployment more attractive. To capitalize on lower global prices, the report says India will need to enable buyers to respond more effectively to short-term LNG price opportunities. That would require further liberalisation of LNG terminal capacity bookings and system entry charges, improving access for buyers and helping address historically low utilisation rates at import terminals. The report also argues that gas will struggle to compete with coal unless transmission infrastructure expands significantly. “If gas is going to compete more effectively with coal, new transmission lines - underpinned by competitive transport tariffs - will be needed to provide reliable supply to the north, east and centre of the country where the gas network exists but is sparse,” it said adding in many coal-dominated regions, insufficient pipeline utilisation has kept delivered gas costs high and discouraged new cus-

tomers. “Progress will require reforms to market design, regulation and pricing, as well as further liberalisation of terminal capacity bookings and system entry charges,” it said. The report said lower wholesale gas prices alone will not be sufficient to drive higher gas consumption. Greater investment in infrastructure, commercial contracting and broader market reforms will also be needed to increase the role of gas in India’s energy mix. It argues that meaningful investment is unlikely without fundamental reform of wholesale gas pricing. India’s pricing framework has undergone multiple changes over the past decade, shifting from a heavily regulated system to hub-linked pricing in 2015 before being revised again in 2022 to link domestic prices to oil. While the latest mechanism moderated prices after the global energy shock, domestic gas prices have remained above USD 7 per million British thermal units even as the earlier hub-linked formula would have resulted in lower prices, the analysis notes. Although the Gulf crisis has raised questions about LNG’s reliability as an import source, the report says some of those risks can be mitigated through a more diversified import portfolio.



NEW DELHI: Capital expenditure across sectors driving demand for mining and construction equipment (MCE) is projected to rise from about Rs 5.5 lakh crore in 2025 to Rs 9-10 lakh crore by 2030, creating a long-term growth opportunity for domestic manufacturers and exporters, according to a joint report by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) and Boston Consulting Group (BCG). The report, titled “Pressing the Throttle: How India’s Mining and Construction Equipment Industry Can Support Domestic Ambitions and Become a Global Force”, said India’s infrastructure, manufacturing, mining and energy transition plans are expected to drive sustained demand for mining and construction equipment over the coming decades. “The domestic runway remains long. India’s Viksit Bharat trajectory implies a build-out across infrastructure, manufacturing, critical minerals, and the energy transition that runs for decades. Capital expenditure in MCE-linked sectors is expected to rise from about INR 5.5 lakh crore in 2025 to INR 9-10 lakh crore by 2030,” the report said. It added that India’s Mining and Construction Equipment industry could expand significantly over the long term, reaching \$180-200 billion by 2047 under the Viksit Bharat roadmap. “On the Viksit Bharat trajectory, the MCE sector could

reach an estimated \$180-200 billion by 2047 driven by domestic demand and global exports,” the report said. The report noted that India has already emerged as one of the world’s fastest-growing MCE markets, with domestic demand exceeding \$17 billion in 2025 and growing at 10-12 per cent annually. It also highlighted the country’s improving export performance. “India’s MCE exports have nearly tripled over the last decade, from \$1.7 billion in 2015 to around \$4.9 billion in 2025... The country crossed from net importer to net exporter of mining and construction equipment,” it said. Despite that progress, the report said India still accounts for less than 4 per cent of global mining and construction equipment imports, leaving substantial room for export growth. “The export headroom is significant. Globally, countries import around \$150 billion worth of mining and construc-

tion equipment, but less than 4 per cent of that demand is currently supplied by India,” it said, adding that Southeast Asia, Africa, the Gulf and South America offer the biggest near-term opportunities as companies diversify supply chains beyond China. The report also pointed to India’s relatively low level of mechanisation as another major growth driver. “Mechanisation intensity also remains below global benchmarks at roughly half the global level,” it said, indicating significant scope for higher equipment demand and productivity gains. To strengthen India’s position as a global manufacturing and export hub, the report recommended deeper localisation of high-value components, greater investment in research and development, wider adoption of digital and low-emission equipment, stronger supplier ecosystems and closer collaboration between government and industry. ANI

Maruti Suzuki eyes 9 lakh units of CNG vehicle sales this fiscal

NEW DELHI: Car maker leader Maruti Suzuki India is aiming to sell around 9 lakh CNG vehicles, a nearly 30 per cent increase in the ongoing fiscal, with demand for such automobiles rising in the wake of the West Asia war, according to a senior company official. The demand for CNG vehicles is no longer restricted to small cars and vans, but it has also seen a rise even in the company’s SUVs, Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL) Senior Executive Officer, Marketing & Sales, Partho Banerjee said. “In the first quarter of this fiscal, we have sold 2.2 lakh units of CNG vehicles across models, which is a growth of 58 per cent over the same quarter last year,” Banerjee said when asked about the traction of CNG vehicles currently in the market. Banerjee said due to the fuel price hike after the West Asia war, demand for CNG vehicles has shot up. Asked what the target for CNG vehicle sales this fiscal is, he said, considering how CNG vehicle sales have grown in the first quarter, for the full year we are targeting around 9 lakh units. Maruti Suzuki India currently sells 15 CNG models, including light commercial vehicles, in the domestic market. In fiscal 2025-26, it sold more than 7 lakh units of CNG vehicles. PTI

Hindustan Zinc plans ₹5K cr capex for FY27, 80% for current projects

NEW DELHI: Vedanta group firm Hindustan Zinc Limited (HZL) is likely to spend about \$500-600 million (around Rs 5,000 crore) in the current financial year, with most of the capital earmarked for projects already underway and a smaller portion reserved for new initiatives, its Chief Executive Officer Arun Misra said. Misra said roughly 80 per cent of the guidance is intended for projects that are currently running, while about 20 per cent will be allocated to new projects that the firm plans to announce soon. He added that the group’s total project capacity is about 1 million tonnes, of which 250,000 tonnes (25 per cent) has already been approved with a capital expenditure (capex) of

Rs 12,000 crore covering mining and mineralisation. Orders for mining have been placed and construction of the smelter has started, but milling and concentrate-related orders are yet to be finalised, the CEO said. The remaining capacity will require investment in a similar proportion to reach 650 KT, with the expenditure expected to be phased over the next 4-5 years. That translates to an average annual capex of about Rs 7,000-8,000 crore, he said, noting that in the current year only 15-20 per cent of that multi-year outlay will be reflected in actual cash outflows. He did not disclose any further timeline or detailed financial break-up for the new projects. PTI

Hindustan Zinc -- a major zinc-lead producer in India and a subsidiary of Vedanta Limited -- has been investing to boost capacity and improve efficiencies across its operations in recent years. The company is a leader in essential metals like zinc, lead, and silver with over five decades of operational excellence. The company operates across the entire value chain, from ore to metal, through fully mechanised underground mines and digitally advanced smelting facilities. Backed by the Vedanta Group, Hindustan Zinc Limited is listed on the BSE and the NSE, with 60.71 per cent ownership by Vedanta Limited and 27.92 per cent held by the Centre. PTI

CBDT issues detailed reporting guidance for crypto exchanges under I-T Act, 2025

NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has issued a detailed guidance note to help crypto-asset service providers comply with reporting obligations under the Income-tax Act, 2025. The guidance does not create a new tax regime for virtual digital assets but clarifies reporting requirements for crypto exchanges and other intermediaries under existing tax laws. The note also marks the implementation of India’s adoption of the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development’s (OECD) Crypto-Asset Reporting Framework (CARF), aimed at enabling automatic exchange of tax-related information on crypto-assets among participating countries. CBDT Chairman Ravi



Agarwal said the rapid growth of crypto-assets had created challenges as such assets can be issued, held and transferred outside traditional financial systems and across borders, potentially escaping reporting obligations applicable to conventional financial institutions. The guidance defines a crypto-asset as a “digital representation of value” using cryptographically secured distributed ledger technology or similar systems to validate and secure transactions. It clarifies

that classification depends on the functionality of the asset rather than labels such as cryptocurrency, security token or non-fungible token. However, not all crypto-assets fall under reporting requirements. Only “relevant crypto-assets” are subject to due diligence and reporting obligations for Reporting Crypto-Asset Service Providers (RCASPs). Certain assets, including Central Bank Digital Currencies (CBDCs), specified electronic money products and crypto-assets that cannot reasonably be used for investment or payment purposes, are excluded from reporting requirements. Under the framework, RCASPs must identify reportable users and persons whose details are required to be sub-

mitted to tax authorities. These include crypto users who are tax residents of jurisdictions outside India and certain controlling persons of entity users that do not qualify for exemptions. Once identified as reportable, service providers must submit user identification details along with information on crypto transactions. The rules also cover “reportable retail payment transactions” involving relevant crypto-assets used for purchasing goods or services where the value exceeds \$50,000. The CBDT said the guidance is designed to help crypto intermediaries implement reporting rules uniformly & strengthen India’s commitment to global tax transparency standards and cross-border exchange of information. AGENCIES

Concerns over E20 fuel persist as 67% older vehicle owners report mileage drop: Survey

NEW DELHI: More than a year after India completed the nationwide rollout of E20 petrol, concerns over its impact on vehicle performance continue to persist, with a majority of owners of older petrol vehicles reporting lower mileage & higher maintenance costs, a LocalCircles survey said. The survey found that 67% of owners of pre-2023 petrol vehicles reported a mileage decline of more than 10% since early 2025, while nearly half said they had witnessed increased wear and tear or repair expenses. The findings are based on over 45,000 responses from petrol vehicle owners across 309 districts. Among 22,541



respondents who answered the mileage-related question, nearly one-fourth reported a reduction exceeding 20%, while only 13% said they saw no impact on mileage. The survey noted that consumer complaints have remained largely unchanged from earlier studies, indicating that the issue may be persistent rather than temporary.

Respondents cited problems such as rough idling, increased engine vibrations, harder cold starts, reduced pickup and frequent repairs. Around 45% of owners of pre-2023 petrol vehicles reported unusual wear and tear involving components such as engines, fuel lines, fuel pumps, injectors and fuel tanks. The share of respondents reporting maintenance issues has increased from 29% in May 2026 to 45% in the latest survey. A separate survey of over 22,000 owners of petrol vehicles purchased in 2023 and 2024 found that 59% reported a mileage decline of more than 10%, despite these vehicles being

marketed as E20 compatible. LocalCircles said the reported mileage losses were higher than government estimates and called for independent testing of ethanol content and fuel quality at retail outlets. It also raised concerns over possible adulteration or contamination in the fuel supply chain. The government has maintained that E20 may reduce mileage in older vehicles by around 3-5%, while studies by agencies including the Automotive Research Association of India have indicated a 2-6% decline. Officials have also said there is no conclusive evidence linking E20 to engine damage in compliant vehicles. AGENCIES

Air India to modify Boeing 787 over possible door assist handle issue

NEW DELHI: Air India is carrying out certain modifications in some of its Boeing 787 planes to address a possible issue with door assist handles, sources said against the backdrop of the US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) issuing an airworthiness directive regarding the issue. FAA, earlier this month, adopted the directive for certain Boeing 787-8, 787-9 and 787-10 models after reports of door assist handles pulled loose from their lower attach point in the doorway support bracket during pre-flight checks. The watchdog has asked airlines to make modifications in certain models since detach-



ment of door assist handles could cause injuries to passengers, crew or maintenance personnel when opening the door. Currently, Air India has a fleet of 35 Dreamliners, comprising 26 legacy Boeing 787-8s and 9 Boeing 787-9s. Out of the 787-9s, 3 are new, and the remaining 6 are from erstwhile Vistara. Air India has a total of 185

planes, including narrow-bodies and wide-bodies. One of the sources said the airline is aware of the FAA’s airworthiness directive and there is no impact on the current flight operations or safety aspects. In line with the directive, Air India is carrying out the necessary modifications in a phased manner, and modifications have been completed for some of the legacy aircraft, the source said. Details about the number of Air India Dreamliners that need modifications could not be ascertained. There were no official comments from Air India and Boeing. PTI

‘Indian single malts leap to half a million cases in 2025, desi cos dominate with 92% share’

Within the ‘Made in India’ Single Malt Whisky category, brands made by Indian companies account for the dominant share of sales, the CIABC said

NEW DELHI: Indian single malt whisky, which has won several global awards and gained international fame in the last couple of years for its craftsmanship, are estimated to have grown to about 5 lakh cases in 2025, registering a growth of approximately 22 per cent, according to data released by the Confederation of Indian Alcoholic Beverage Companies (CIABC). This growth has been primarily driven by homegrown desi labels such as Amrut, Ram-pur, Indri, and Paul John, along with newer entrants, including Solan Gold, GianChand,

Doaab, Crazy Cock, Aaghaz, and Gamber Valley, as the category gains stronger traction within India’s premium and luxury spirits space, CIABC said. Moreover, the desi companies continue to dominate the ‘Made in India’ Single Malt Whisky landscape, accounting for an estimated 92 per cent of category sales in 2025. Indian single malt whisky brands such as Diageo’s Godawan and Pernod Ricard’s Longitude 77, which are owned and backed by foreign and multinational companies, are estimated to account for around 7

per cent of the category with 35,000 cases (of nine litres each). “Within the ‘Made in India’ Single Malt Whisky category, brands made by Indian companies account for the dominant share of sales. For 2025, Indian manufacturers are estimated to account for around 92 per cent of the category, translating to approximately 4.65 lakh cases,” it said. The ‘Made in India’ Single Malt Whisky category has maintained a strong growth trajectory over the past three years, expanding from an estimated 3.5 lakh nine-litre cases

CLOSER LOOK

» ‘Made in India’ Single Malt Whisky has expanded from an estimated 3.5 lakh nine-litre cases in 2023 to around 4 lakh cases in 2024 and to about 5 lakh cases in 2025

» This reflects a cumulative increase of nearly 43% over two years, highlighting the rapid premiumisation of India’s whisky market and rising consumer acceptance

» Together, imported and locally produced single malts have expanded overall market to around 8.5 lakh cases

in 2023 to around 4 lakh cases in 2024 and further to approximately 5 lakh cases in 2025. This reflects a cumulative increase of nearly 43 per cent over two years, highlighting the

rapid premiumisation of India’s whisky market and rising consumer acceptance of Indian-origin single malts, in which the entry-level options start around Rs 2,300 while pre-

mium or aged flagship expressions are commonly sold at Rs 5,500-8,000. CIABC Director General Anant S Iyer said Indian single malts are increasingly gaining recognition among consumers for their quality, distinctive taste profile and premium positioning. “Once viewed as a niche category, Indian single malts are increasingly being recognised for their distinctive taste profile, climate-led maturation, award-winning quality, specialised cask finishes and Indian provenance. They are finding stronger acceptance among

consumers looking for premium luxury whisky options,” Iyer said. However, CIABC data also reflects that imported single malt whiskies (which are bottled-in-origin) continue to hold a significant presence in the Indian market, with their volumes estimated at around 3.5 lakh cases (of nine litres) in 2025. Together, imported and locally produced single malts have expanded the overall market to around 8.5 lakh cases, reflecting a growing appetite among Indian consumers for premium, craft-led and

provenance-driven whisky experiences. Iyer said Indian single malt whisky has evolved beyond being a niche, award-driven category and is now emerging as a significant premium spirits segment. “Indian single malt is no longer only an awards-led story; it is becoming a measurable premium spirits category. Indian companies continue to lead this space with several new domestic players lining up launches and global companies operating in India also investing in Indian-origin single malts,” he said. PTI

FM directs I-T dept to work for benefit of common people

She cited challenges faced by the dept in getting approval to construct building in the Nariman Point, which she inaugurated on Sunday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Sunday urged the Income Tax department to work for the benefit of common people without making them run from pillar to post.

She also went public with her disappointment at the “laid-back” nature of government departments, which leads to illegal occupation or encroachments on government lands and underlined the need for integrity in conduct from all officials.

Citing the challenges faced by the department in getting permissions to construct a building in the Nariman Point business district, which she inaugurated on Sunday, Sitharaman said these experiences, despite serving in the Indian Revenue Service (IRS), would have given them an idea of what the common man goes through.

An IRS officer has the name of the Income Tax department behind him, a “powerful force to frighten people”, Sitharaman reminded, adding that despite this, the officials had to run from pillar to post to get clearances from authorities to proceed with work on the 13-floor building.



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

Sitharaman said these experiences, despite serving in the Indian Revenue Service, would have given them an idea of what the common man goes through

“Can this (experience) incentivise you to understand the position of a common citizen when he approaches you? Don’t make them run from pillar to post where your authority is required; do the work for them,” the FM said.

The minister was quick to say that she is not asking the officials to break the rules or do something out of the way

for the common citizens but rued that it takes a lot of effort in this country for people to get their rightful claims.

The land parcel on which Aaykar Sindhu, the 1.13 lakh sq ft building, is built, had been with the I-T department since 1973, Sitharaman said, adding that despite this, illegal occupations had sprouted up on the land.

HIGHLIGHTS

» An IRS officer has the name of the Income Tax department behind him, a ‘powerful force to frighten people’, Sitharaman reminded

» despite this, the officials had to run from pillar to post to get clearances from authorities to proceed with work on the 13-floor building

» The minister said that she is not asking officials to break the rules but rued that it takes a lot of effort in this country for people to get their rightful claims

“The fact that you led it to have occupations, illegal occupation, shows somewhere in our governance, we are too laid back. It is somebody’s job to take care of our assets, and when it is encroached, we say, oh, we have the land, but we can’t build it,” she said. Sitharaman also promised to look into the issue of many of the I-T officials not staying in official accommo-

dations in Mumbai and Navi Mumbai areas, hinting that half of them do not enjoy such a facility and also travel for long to get to workplaces.

Stating that she would prefer government-to-government transfer of lands for the purpose, Sitharaman assured that she will facilitate the quick transfer of lands and other aspects like getting the permissions, building, dealing with CPWD (Central Public Works Department), assigning contracts and tenders will be the job I-T officials will have to perform.

“Get it all done at the earliest so that we do not get into the second half of the 21st century with scattered office spaces, rental accommodation in a city, which is fast growing and expect to pay rents or lease rental at phenomenal rates,” she said.

She particularly mentioned state-run BSNL, asking officials to get the telco’s land and promised to speak with her counterpart minister.

Meanwhile, she also used the opportunity to underline the importance of integrity in the discharge of a critical work like tax collection for the country.

“Integrity is the one and only principle I will advocate to each one of you,” she said.

Parliamentary panel asks CCI to curb competition law violations

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Fair trade watchdog CCI should vigorously enforce the determination of penalty guidelines to curb the risk of repeated competition law violations being internalised as a “mere cost of doing business”, according to a Parliamentary panel.

These guidelines provide for repeated competition law contraventions as an aggravating factor while imposing penalties to ensure that such offences do not happen in the future, the Committee on Subordinate Legislation of the Rajya Sabha said.

The recommendation is part of the report tabled this week in Parliament by the committee chaired by Milind Murli Deora on the Competition Commission of India (CCI).

In the report, the committee said vigorous antitrust enforcement is indispensable to ensure that the least advantaged are not further disadvantaged by unfair or anti-competitive conduct.

“Small businesses, MSMEs, startups etc should be able to depend upon a steady and vigorous enforcement of the competitive laws to safeguard their ability to compete...,” the committee said.

The panel also raised concerns over the issue of repeated contraventions of competition laws and regulations by corporate entities.

“Such repeated contraventions risk being internalised as a mere ‘cost of doing busi-



The guidelines treat repeated competition law violations as an aggravating factor for penalties to deter future offences, the Rajya Sabha panel said

ness,’ thereby severely undermining the deterrent effect of the laws and regulations,” the committee said.

Against this backdrop, the committee noted that CCI should vigorously enforce the Determination of Monetary Penalty Guidelines, which provide for repeated contraventions as an aggravating factor, so as to ensure deterrence for future offences.

The committee examined CCI’s regulations on commitment, settlement, determination of turnover or income, and determination of monetary penalty guidelines.

Another recommendation of the panel is that the corporate affairs ministry and

KEY POINTS

- » ‘Vigorous antitrust enforcement is indispensable to ensure that least advantaged are not further disadvantaged by anti-competitive conduct’
- » The panel also raised concerns over issue of repeated contraventions of competition laws and regulations by corporate entities
- » ‘Corporate affairs ministry, CCI should undertake periodical review of regulatory framework of the competition law’

Competition Commission of India should undertake a periodical review of the regulatory architecture of the whole gamut of the competitive law framework.

According to the committee, the reviews should involve comprehensive stakeholder consultations and systematically benchmark the domestic framework against global best practices.

“The committee feels that competition laws should keep up with the pace of change, especially in the digital era and that they must be updated from time to time to deal more effectively with new problems and specific challenges,” the report said.

Top-9 companies lose ₹2.74 lakh cr in mcap

From the top-10 pack, Hindustan Unilever emerged as the only winner

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of nine of the top-10 most valued firms eroded by Rs 2.74 lakh crore last week, in tandem with a bearish trend in equities, with HDFC Bank taking the biggest hit.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex tanked 2,091.68 points, or 2.67 per cent, and the NSE Nifty declined 566.85 points, or 2.32 per cent.

“Markets witnessed a weak and volatile week, with benchmark indices extending their losing streak as a sharp surge in crude oil prices and renewed geopolitical tensions weighed heavily on investor sentiment,” Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

Banking stocks emerged as the biggest drag following mixed Q1 FY27 earnings, while a risk-off environment



Last week, BSE Sensex tanked 2,091.68 points, or 2.67% & NSE Nifty declined 566.85 points, or 2.32%

and weakness in the rupee further curtailed buying interest, he added.

From the top-10 pack, Hindustan Unilever emerged as the

only winner.

Those who faced erosion from their valuation were Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL), Bharti Airtel, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), Bajaj Finance, Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) and Larsen & Toubro.

The market valuation of HDFC Bank tumbled Rs 1,18,383.91 crore to reach Rs 11,43,985.90 crore.

Reliance Industries’ valuation eroded by Rs 65,429.82 crore to Rs 17,29,661.44 crore.

The valuation of State Bank of India tanked Rs 26,814.94 crore to Rs 9,36,953.84 crore and that of Bajaj Finance dropped by Rs 26,802.74 crore to Rs 6,30,471.54 crore.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of LIC declined by Rs

15,116.74 crore to Rs 5,33,007.56 crore and that of ICICI Bank diminished by Rs 6,223.84 crore to Rs 10,28,217.93 crore.

Bharti Airtel’s valuation edged lower by Rs 6,021.64 crore to Rs 11,85,046.13 crore and that of TCS dipped Rs 5,191.95 crore to Rs 8,15,480.75 crore.

The mcap of Larsen & Toubro faced an erosion of Rs 4,092.79 crore to Rs 5,20,747.89 crore.

However, the mcap of Hindustan Unilever climbed Rs 152.73 crore to Rs 5,03,928.59 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the most valued firm, followed by Bharti Airtel, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, LIC, Larsen & Toubro and Hindustan Unilever. PTI

‘Oil prices, US Fed rate decision & West Asia crisis to drive markets’

NEW DELHI: Developments around the West Asia conflict, crude oil prices and the US Fed interest rate decision would be the key drivers for market movement this week, analysts said.

Besides, quarterly earnings would drive sentiments in the market, they added.

“Developments surrounding the US-Iran conflict, shipping activity through the Strait of Hormuz, and movements in crude oil prices will remain key drivers of global risk sentiment. In addition, investors will closely monitor the US Federal Reserve’s policy meeting, where interest rate guidance and commentary on inflation will be critical for global markets,” Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

On the domestic front, market participants will track



June Industrial Production (IIP) data, he added.

Major companies reporting earnings this week include Coal India, BEL, Larsen & Toubro, Hindustan Unilever, Adani Enterprises, Asian Paints, Adani Ports, Bajaj Finance, Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Steel, Maruti Suzuki, ITC, and Sun Pharma, Praveesh Gour, Senior Technical Analyst at Swastika Investmart Ltd, said.

“Investor attention in the week ahead is expected to remain firmly anchored on

developments in the Middle East, with the escalating conflict between the US and Iran continuing to dominate global market sentiment. The sharp rise in crude oil prices has revived concerns over inflation, economic growth and the outlook for monetary policy, keeping investors in a defensive, risk-averse stance,” Ponnudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

The US Federal Reserve’s policy meeting will be the defining macro event of the week. While markets overwhelmingly expect policymakers to leave interest rates unchanged, the recent surge in energy prices has prompted some investors to question whether inflation risks could remain elevated for longer, he said. PTI

‘US Fed action & oil swings to test bullion this week’

NEW DELHI: Gold and silver are heading into a crucial week, with the Federal Reserve’s interest rate decision, oil price movement and the US-Iran conflict determining whether bullion extends its recovery or comes under renewed pressure, analysts said.

Apart from the Fed’s decision, investors will monitor US Consumer Confidence, Core Personal Consumption Expenditures (PCE) inflation data, weekly jobless claims.

On the domestic front, gold futures for August delivery rose Rs 2,200, or 1.6 per cent, to close at Rs 1.43 lakh per 10 grams during the last week.

Silver futures for September delivery gained Rs 5,735, or 2.7 per cent, to Rs 2.22 lakh per kilogram on the Multi Commodity Exchange.

Globally, Comex gold futures for August delivery advanced \$52, or 1.3 per cent, to settle at \$4,070.8 per ounce and silver for the September contract rose \$3, or nearly 5 per cent, to \$58.90 per ounce in New York.

Analysts said bullion witnessed sharp swings during the week after Brent crude briefly reclaimed the \$100-per-barrel mark, following Houthi strikes on Saudi-owned vessels, stoking fears of supply disruptions.

However, oil later retreated as investors booked profits, helping gold and silver recover towards the end of the week. PTI

Nippon India MF tops mutual fund industry with over 4 crore folios

NEW DELHI: Nippon India Mutual Fund has become the first asset management company in the country to cross the 4-crore folio milestone, according to industry data.

As per the data from the Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi), the mutual fund industry had 27.86 crore folios at the end of June, with Nippon India MF accounting for 14.4 per cent (4.02 crore folios) of the total.

Also, the fund house said it had the industry’s largest unique investor base at 2.41 crore, accounting for 39 per cent of the industry’s 6.19 crore unique investors.

“We are humbled to have the trust of 4 crore investors and a 39 per cent share of India’s

unique investor base. This milestone reflects the wealth creation journey we have enabled for millions of retail investors,” Sundeeep Sikka, MD and CEO of Nippon Life India Asset Management, said.

He added that the company continues to channel household savings into India’s capital markets while facilitating Japanese investors’ participation in India’s growth story.

Among other major fund houses, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund had 3.18 crore folios, followed by HDFC Mutual Fund at 3.11 crore, SBI Mutual Fund at 2.24 crore and UTI Mutual Fund at 1.42 crore.

The remaining fund houses in the top 10 by folio count were Axis Mutual Fund (1.35 crore),

Tata Mutual Fund (1.28 crore), Kotak Mahindra Mutual Fund (1.19 crore), Aditya Birla Sun Life Mutual Fund (1.11 crore) and DSP Mutual Fund (1.03 crore).

Collectively, the top 10 AMCs accounted for 19.94 crore folios, or 71.6 per cent of the industry’s total, while the remaining fund houses contributed 7.92 crore folios, representing 28.4 per cent.

The industry had 6.19 crore unique investors as at June-end, indicating that the average investor holds multiple mutual fund accounts across schemes and fund houses.

The gap between folio count and unique investors reflects increasing portfolio diversification among retail investors. PTI

‘PNB profit to cross ₹20,000 cr mark in FY27’

NEW DELHI: Enthused by the consistent financial performance of the last four quarters, Punjab National Bank (PNB) MD and CEO Ashok Chandra exuded confidence that the bank’s profit would surpass the Rs 20,000 crore mark this financial year.

The public sector lender had earned a net profit of Rs 16,904 crore in the previous financial year.

From the second quarter of last financial year, the bank has been maintaining a net profit of over Rs 5,000 crore every quarter, Chandra told PTI in an interview.

“We have maintained the same trend in the first quarter (ongoing financial year). And I am hopeful and confident that with the profitable growth, which is happening in the system....we will be surpass-



ing the Rs 5,000 crore number and every quarter will be reaching a new height,” he said.

Asked if the bank can cross the Rs 20,000 crore mark during FY27 at this run rate, he said, “If I am telling that every quarter Rs 5,000 crore of net profit will happen, I think that goes to that figure which you are talking about.”

To achieve the target, he said, the bank is focusing heavily on conducting mega outreach activities every quarter

on a very large scale.

Besides, he said, retail, agri, MSME, and self-help groups are going to be the focus areas for asset creation.

Overall, loan growth will be 12-13 per cent while deposits would be growing at 9-10 per cent during the ongoing financial year, he added.

Chandra also said the bank would enter into acquisition finance in the third quarter of the current financial year as the RBI recently opened the window for lenders.

Earlier this year, the Reserve Bank came out with final guidelines on acquisition finance by banks, increasing the lending limit to up to 75 per cent of the deal value from the 70 per cent proposed in the draft rules.

“The acquisition finance market is a very, very big mar-

ket and ample opportunities are there in the system. We have got our policy approved for the acquisition financing in the last board meeting,” he said.

“We are looking for a good partner and then maybe from Q3 onwards, we will be initiating some work in the acquisition financing.”

To begin with, he said, the bank would be starting acquisition finance with the domestic entities, and this will help the bank to diversify its asset portfolio.

While permitting the activity from July 1, the RBI listed out a set of conditions to be met while banks do such financing activities, including a corporate guarantee from the acquiring company and ensuring that the debt-to-equity ratio does not exceed 3:1 post-acquisition on a continuous basis. PTI

IPO Buzz: Over a dozen firms, including Zepto set for debut next month

The upcoming issues, expected to collectively raise over Rs 25,000 crore, include a mix of fresh equity issuances & offer for sale, merchant bankers said

NEW DELHI: Coming month is likely to witness an IPO rush with more than a dozen companies, including Zepto, Truhome Finance and logistics platform Shiprocket gearing up to launch their initial share sale.

The upcoming issues, expected to collectively raise over Rs 25,000 crore, include a mix of fresh equity issuances and offer for sale (OFS) component, merchant bankers said.

“With markets stabilising and investor sentiment improving, companies that were waiting on the sidelines are now

moving ahead with their IPO plans,” said Bhavesh Shah, MD & Head-Investment Banking at Equirus Capital.

Among the largest offerings, Zepto plans to raise up to Rs 8,010 crore through a fresh issue, along with an OFS of up to 11.34 crore equity shares.

Housing finance company Truhome has proposed a Rs 3,000-crore IPO, comprising a fresh issue of up to Rs 1,500 crore and an OFS of an equal amount.

Elevate Campuses intends to raise Rs 2,550 crore entirely



through a fresh issue, while Shiprocket has filed for a Rs 2,342.35-crore IPO, including a fresh issue of up to Rs 1,100 crore and an OFS worth Rs 1,242.35 crore.

CLOSER LOOK

- » Zepto plans to raise up to Rs 8,010 cr through a fresh issue, along with an OFS of up to 11.34 cr equity shares
- » Truhome has proposed Rs 3K cr IPO, comprising a fresh issue of up to Rs 1,500 cr & an OFS of an equal amount
- » Moreover, Manipal Health Enterprises & Juniper Green Energy are set to open their IPOs on July 29 & July 30

Other companies preparing to hit the capital markets include Innovatiview India (up to Rs 2,000 crore, entirely through OFS) and Milky Mist Dairy Food (Rs 1,553 crore).

In addition, Dhoot Transmission, ARCIL (Asset Reconstruction Company India Ltd), Ardee Industries, Gaja Alternative Asset Management, Rays of Belief, Hy-Tech Engineers,

Shankesh Jewellers and Learnfluence Education are also planning to launch their maiden public offerings.

The fresh pipeline comes amid sustained activity in the primary market, reflecting improving investor sentiment and healthy demand for new listings.

Market participants expect IPO activity to remain buoyant as companies look to capitalise on favourable fundraising conditions.

So far this year, 36 companies have launched their

IPOs, including nine that hit the primary market this month.

Moreover, Manipal Health Enterprises and Juniper Green Energy are set to open their public issues on July 29 and July 30, respectively. MV Electrosystems is also scheduled to launch its IPO next week.

Looking ahead, Shah said the long-term outlook for India’s IPO market remains strong despite periodic volatility.

“The primary market has undergone a structural transformation, with equity becom-

ing an increasingly preferred source of growth capital. While there will always be tactical pauses driven by market volatility, the underlying pipeline remains very strong. I continue to expect India to raise around USD 20 billion through IPOs this calendar year,” he said.

He added that well-priced IPOs are likely to continue delivering healthy returns, while aggressively valued offerings may witness limited upside, as investors become increasingly selective rather than indiscriminately bullish. PTI

PROUD FOR NATION

Mirabai wins hat-trick of gold at Commonwealth Games

S.KANNAN

GLASGOW: Olympic medalist Mirabai Chanu underlined her status as India's greatest weightlifter of her generation with a record-shattering third successive Commonwealth Games gold on Sunday.

A picture of confidence, poise and charm, the lady from Manipur smashed the Commonwealth Games record to total 190kg in snatch, clean and jerk in the 48kg weight category.

As the national anthem played, Mirabai Chanu stood facing the national flag and touched her heart, with the gold medal hanging around her neck. She got emotional, as she won the medal for the third time. Mirabai got her first Gold Coast in 2018, then in Birmingham in 2022.

"I am very emotional and happy I could win the first gold medal for India. I shed tears of joy. This medal is for India," Mirabai told Millennium Post.

The tone and tenor for India had been set by a young man from Manipur as Rishikanta Singh won silver in the 60kg category in weightlifting.

"It's a dream come true for



Mirabai Chanu wins gold medal in the women's 48kg Final weightlifting competition at the 23rd Commonwealth Games, in Glasgow on Sunday

me as I am the first man from Manipur to win a medal in weightlifting," said Rishikanta. He thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi and all well-wishers.

The toast of the nation was Mirabai, who had the indoor hall in thrall. She came back from an injury at the Paris Olympics.

It was an important year for her. First, the Commonwealth

Games then the Asian Games. As she stepped onto the platform for the first part of the competition, 85kg in snatch was massive.

There was nobody else in fray who could reach near her effort. After a 10-minute break, Mirabai Chanu was back in action.

This time, when she attempted 105kg in the first effort, it was foul. Later, she

returned in quick time to produce a clean effort. She was so pleased, her face reflected the radiance.

As the announcer reeled of her record at the announcement, Mirabai was pleased as punch.

"I have been almost hungry for three days as I had to keep my weight in control. To bring my weight into 48kg category is tough and I did it,"

Highlights

- » Tears rolled down as she stood proudly on top of the podium
- » Mirabai did not eat and drink for days to maintain weight
- » Olympic medalist won silver in Tokyo, 2021
- » PM Modi described Mirabai's latest triumph as another 'glorious chapter' in India's weightlifting history

she said.

Mirabai's journey has been one of glory.

In 2016, she had failed in the Rio Olympics. But then in Tokyo, in 2021, she won silver medal.

In Paris 2024, Mirabai was off colour. She is past 32 and still breaking records. This is defining, for she is the face of a tough sport in India.

"I am sure I can do well in the Asian Games as well," said Mirabai, who has been training so hard. She has been kept in good shape by a team of physios and experts.

Rishikanta's silver opened new chapter for Manipur

GLASGOW: A troublesome knee took away Rishikanta Singh's chance at Commonwealth Games gold, but it could not stop him from creating history for Manipur.

The Indian lifter arrived in Glasgow carrying the hopes of a state that has long been a powerhouse of Indian weightlifting but had never seen a male lifter participate in the Commonwealth Games.

He came within touching distance of fulfilling his own gold dream before an injury forced him to sign off with silver in the men's 60kg competition. Rishikanta was in the driver's seat after producing a Commonwealth Games record lift of 121kg in the snatch. But a knee injury suffered just a week before the event resurfaced when he moved to the clean and jerk.

He could complete the 'clean' but struggled to generate the power needed to push the bar overhead.

Two failed attempts at 148kg and 151kg meant he managed only 143kg in the section, finishing with a total of 264kg and a silver medal. For Rishikanta, however, the medal carried a significance far beyond its colour.

The 28-year-old became the first male weightlifter from Manipur to win a Commonwealth Games medal and the first man from the state to even



Silver medalist India's Rishikanta Singh poses for photographs during the presentation ceremony in Glasgow on Sunday

The 28-year-old became the first male weightlifter from Manipur to win a Commonwealth Games medal

compete in weightlifting at the Games.

Manipur has produced some of India's finest weightlifters, particularly on the women's side, with athletes from the state becoming synonymous with success on the international stage. But Rishikanta's achievement opened a new chapter by putting men's weightlifting from the state in the spotlight.

His journey to that historic

podium was shaped by struggle long before he stepped onto the Glasgow stage.

Growing up in a modest household in Manipur, Rishikanta saw his family battle financial difficulties. His father worked as a daily-wage labourer, and pursuing a career in sport meant overcoming challenges both inside and outside the training hall.

From those humble beginnings, he slowly carved a path through India's weightlifting system.

He trained at the National Sports Academy in Imphal before progressing through elite programmes, representing the Indian Army and sharpening his skills at some of the country's top training centres.

DURAND CUP

Jamshedpur thrash Defenders FC 5-0

RANCHI: Raynier Fernandes produced a brilliant hat-trick on debut as Jamshedpur FC made a flying start to their Group C campaign in the Durand Cup with a comprehensive 5-0 win over Defenders FC of the Sri Lankan Armed Forces here on Sunday.

Besides Fernandes (4th, 6th, 82nd), Aman C.K. (23rd) and Devendra Dhaku Murgakar (39th) also found the net as the Red Miners dominated proceedings from start to finish. In Kolkata, P Christopher Kamei's stunning free-kick early in the second half proved to be the difference as Indian Army football team secured a 1-0 victory over debutants Samalewari Sporting Club in a Group B fixture at the Kishore Bharati Krirangan.

Kamei curled home the match-winning free-kick in the 47th minute as Indian Army dominated proceedings throughout, creating numerous chances but repeatedly denied by an inspired Aaryan Anjaneya in goal and the woodwork.

At the Birsa Munda Football Stadium in Ranchi, JFC wasted no time in asserting themselves and raced into the lead inside four minutes.

Sanan Mohammed was at the heart of the move, surging down the left flank before delivering a delightful cross into the

six-yard box. Fernandes rose highest to guide a towering header into the near corner and hand Jamshedpur an early advantage in the fourth minute.

The lead was doubled just two minutes later. Lalhriatpuia Chawngthu whipped in another dangerous delivery from the left, with goalkeeper T.S. Priyashan managing only a partial punch.

The loose ball fell kindly to Fernandes outside the penalty area, and the midfielder unleashed a thunderous strike that flew into the back of the net to make it 2-0.

Jamshedpur continued to dominate possession, with Lalhriatpuia, Sanan Mohammed and Aman combining effectively in the attacking third. Sanan repeatedly troubled the visitors down the left, while Defenders FC were forced into desperate clearances, with K.D.S. Sankalpa and captain R.A.C. Madushan working tirelessly to keep the scoreline respectable.

Despite spending long periods without the ball, the Sri Lankan side showed glimpses of attacking intent.

A swift counter-attack in the 18th minute was halted brilliantly by Jamshedpur captain Pronay Halder, whose perfectly timed sliding challenge denied S. Aravinraj a sight of goal.

Chopra seeks 2nd gold, India target more medals this time

GLASGOW: Neeraj Chopra will be up against reigning Olympic champion Arshad Nadeem of Pakistan and Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage of Sri Lanka in a marquee men's javelin clash as India seek to better last edition's medal haul in Commonwealth Games athletics events, beginning here Monday.

Besides Chopra, other Indian gold medal contenders are long jumper Murali Sreesankar, a silver medalist at the 2022 CWG in Birmingham, and high jumper Sarvesh Kushare who recently set the national record of 2.31m.

The Indian team management is hoping for two medals each in men's javelin, long jump, high jump and triple jump, besides podium finishes in men's 10,000m, decathlon and women's 10,000m race walk.

The men's 100m hurdles and shot put as well as women's 3000m steeplechase may also fetch India medals, which could take the haul past the eight (1 gold, 4 silver, 3 bronze) won last time in Birmingham.

But there is no certainty of gold medal count as most of the athletics events have world class fields..

A lower back injury has been troubling Chopra since September 2025 and he made a delayed start to the season at Doha Diamond League on June 19. He finished fourth with a throw of 85.69m -- a modest one by his high standards.

With another round of rehabilitation and training for a month at his training base in Bienne in Switzerland, the 28-year-old two-time Olympic medalist Indian superstar would be looking to repeat his gold-winning performance at 2018 Gold Coast CWG. He reached here on Friday from Switzerland.

Chopra had won gold in Gold Coast with a throw of 86.47m. He missed the 2022



Chopra had won gold in Gold Coast with a throw of 86.47m. He missed the 2022 Games due to an injury

Games due to an injury.

Indian athletics head coach Radhakrishnan Nair, who is expecting the 32-member team to better last edition's eight-medal haul, said Chopra is in "perfect physical shape".

It will, however, be a tough fight for the gold for Chopra in a star-studded field. The men's javelin qualifying round will be on July 30 and the final the next day.

Except for the likes of Curtis Thompson of USA and Julian Weber of Germany, all

the global javelin top stars will be in action in Glasgow.

Besides Chopra, Nadeem and Pathirage, the other competitors include reigning world champion Keshorn Walcott of Trinidad and Tobago, 2022 CWG silver winner Anderson Peters of Grenada and Julius Yego of Kenya.

In the mix will be India's Rohit Yadav, who, in fact, is in the second spot among Commonwealth season leaders with his 87.05m last month. He is also a medal contender. Yashvir Singh is the third Indian in the fray.

Pathirage will start as favourite for gold as he is the lone 90m-plus thrower in the world this season with his 92.62m while winning Rome Diamond League title. The 23-year-old has another three 88m-plus throws and won two DL titles this season.

HARARE: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's remarkably adaptive 81 and an equally solid effort from bowlers led by pacer Mayank Yadav ensured India's smooth 35-run win over Zimbabwe in the third and final T20I here on Sunday.

Along with the victory, India also completed a 3-0 sweep, a fine step-up after surrendering the previous two series to England (0-4) and Ireland (0-2).

Zimbabwe had to bat out of their skin to chase down 193 on a rather sluggish pitch.

But they did not have enough patience or nous for it, ending up at 157 for seven despite Ryan Burl making a fine unbeaten 54. Just like in the previous matches, Zimbabwe lost one too many wickets early as they could not properly use the Power Play segment.

Pacer Yash Thakur (2/45) got rid of Dion Myers and skipper Sikandar Raza off successive balls in the fourth over as the hosts slipped to 34 for three.

Earlier Mayank (3/29), who bowled with heaps of pace and accuracy, had ousted Brian Bennett in the first ball of the innings as Zimbabwe struggled for an early move-on.

It became a trend as the innings progressed despite Indians grassing as many as four catches and conceding couple of boundaries in another sloppy fielding effort.



India's batsman Vaibhav Sooryavanshi gestures after scoring 50 runs during the third T20 match against Zimbabwe on Sunday

Burl played a nice innings of assurance and formed a good 60-run alliance with Wesley Madhevere (28) for the fifth wicket. The Zimbabweans played some forceful shots around the park, but the early damage was too big to mitigate. India too suffered an early jolt, losing a struggling Abhishek Sharma for 2 after opting to bat.

But Sooryavanshi showcased another side of his batting during the 49-ball innings on a slightly tacky pitch at the Harare Sports Club, and

The 15-year-old started in a relatively subdued fashion — first 10 balls produced a mere 11 runs, the next 10 saw the arrival of 15 runs, and eventually his second T20I fifty came in 31 balls.

There were a few stunning shots as one would expect in a Sooryavanshi innings. A straight punch for a four off Brad Evans' yorker and then a 102-metre six off off-spinner Sikandar Raza showed his age-defying power and skills.

My focus is just on technique I've trained for: Neeraj

Chopra will be up against Arshad Nadeem of Pakistan & Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage of SL

S.KANNAN

GLASGOW: Neeraj Chopra has come to Glasgow for the Commonwealth Games, fully aware the nation again expects a gold medal from him. From training to pressure and how he has handled it all over the last eight years, the Tokyo Olympics gold medalist opened up on a range of topics.

Question: Neeraj, you won a Commonwealth Games gold in Gold Coast in 2018. You were a young emerging athlete at that time. Now you are a superstar, what memories do you have?

Neeraj Chopra: Yes, I have great memories from Gold Coast. It was my first senior competition and winning gold was special. That was 2018, almost eight years ago. Now I am back. Whenever I represent my country, it is a great feeling. I am happy to be back on the ground. I feel good and have been working on a few things for a while now.

Question: The nature of the competition has changed a lot in the last eight years. You've won gold and silver



India's Neeraj Chopra ahead of the marquee men's javelin event at the Commonwealth Games 2026, in Glasgow

at the last two Olympics, but the competition in Asia has got tougher. Your thoughts?

Neeraj Chopra: Tough competition pushes us athletes to do better. There's strong competition in Asia, especially South Asia. Everyone will push themselves.

Question: In Indian athletics if we look at track and field, so many records have been broken in the last year.

What do you think is driving these revolutionary changes?

Neeraj Chopra: Honestly, there's a lot of support from the private sector now, and the federation (AFI) is very proactive. Athletes are getting international exposure.

But the biggest factor is that our athletes are fearless now.

Earlier, there was hesitation and doubt when compet-

ing against foreign athletes, but now there's confidence, hard work, and self-belief. That's why records are broken.

Question: The weather here in Glasgow is cold. Will the weather and wind conditions be a challenge?

Neeraj Chopra: Yes, yesterday during my training throws, the wind conditions were tough. But it's the same for everyone.

No matter how tough the conditions are, you have to stay mentally strong and think about doing your best in the worst conditions.

Question: Are you targeting a specific mark or opponent? What's your mindset at present?

Neeraj Chopra: My focus is just on technique I've trained for. I don't keep a specific distance target in mind.

The goal is to give 100% on that day so there are no regrets later. Conditions like weather or wind will vary, but I'll give my best performance.

Question: You've won gold before in the Commonwealth Games? How important is this event for you

today?

Neeraj Chopra: Representing my country is always important to me. If I'm competing for India, I will give my 100%. That's always my goal, and it's the same for our other athletes too.

Question: How is your fitness right now?

Neeraj Chopra: It's good now. After the World Championships, last year, I worked on my weak areas and fitness. I'm feeling much better than before.

Question: After the Commonwealth Games, there's a short gap before the Asian Games. How do you feel about this schedule?

Neeraj Chopra: Usually, our off-season starts around September or October, and competitions resume in April or May.

But this time, after the Commonwealth Games, there's a packed schedule with the Diamond League, World Championships, and Asian Games.

The goal is to stay consistent and maintain good form throughout.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public at large is notified and informed that the below mentioned Original Documents :-

- Original Demand letter dated 21/07/2018 issued by BCC Infrastructure P. Ltd. in favour of Mr. Rajesh Sultania,
- Original TPT executed between BCC Infrastructure P. Ltd. and Mr. Rajesh Sultania and IHFL,
- Original Payment receipt dated 20/07/2018 for Rs. 38668/-, dated 09/09/2013 for Rs. 270025/-, dated 27/01/2016 for Rs. 209374/- and dated 27/01/2016 for Rs. 203645/- issued by BCC Infrastructure P. Ltd. in favour of Mr. Rajesh Sultania,
- Original Allotment Letter dated 21/07/2018 issued by BCC Infrastructure P. Ltd. in favour of Mr. Rajesh Sultania, Original PTM dated 21/07/2018 issued by BCC Infrastructure P. Ltd. in favour of IHFL, are missing documents. Relating to Mr. Rajesh Sultania of property FLAT NO. G3 - 887 TOWER G3, 8TH FLOOR, BHARAT CITY, INDRAPRASTHA INDARAPRASTHA YOJNA, GHAZIABAD, UTTAR PRADESH, 201001, mortgaged by Mr. Rajesh Sultania along with Co - borrowers with Sammaan Capital Limited as security under Loan Account No. HHLNOI00466582, have been misplaced at Gurugram. All efforts were made to trace out the above said original documents but all in vain. An online FIR has also been lodged on 21-07-2026 Vide application no. 132270612600875 in this regard.

In case any body who could have found the above mentioned document, is hereby requested to intimate / return the same to Mr. Satpal Singh Rana, or contact him on his landline No. 0124-6048286 of our Head Office at 1st Floor, DLF Corporate Greens, Tower 3A, Southern Peripheral Road, Sector 74A, Gurugram.

sd/-
Authorized officer
SAMMAAN CAPITAL LIMITED

Place : Gurugram

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

E-Tendering Tender Notice
No.38/2026

Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.)
N.E.Railways Izatnagar For and behalf of President of India invites "OPEN" e-tender through on Line (E-tendering) for the following works.

S.N.1:- Description of works: Flash Butt welding of 260 mtr long rail panels, 13/26/39m long rails in connection with "TRR (P)- 57.6 TKM and TTR(TWS)-19 sets in Rampur-Lalkuan section" under ADEN KPV of IZN division N.E.Railway. Approx. Value (Rs.): ₹ 9,11,47,674.20, E.M.D Money (Rs.): ₹ 18,23,000/- Cost of Tender Forms Rs. NIL, Completion time /period from the date of issue of acceptance letter 06 Months.

1. On line e-tender can be submitted up to 15.00 hrs of dated 17.08.2026. 2.For Full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in. Divisional Railway manager(Engg) CPRO-W-244 Izatnagar

Never travel on roof and foot boards.

MEET RHIYA AHIR

THE FACE BEHIND NEET PROTEST'S VIRAL IMAGE

The Mumbai model played no hero on screen, but became one in real life with a single act of defiance



OUR CORRESPONDENT

Every mass movement leaves behind one image that defines it for generations. The nationwide student protests over the NEET paper leak, launched by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) and culminating in the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, have produced several powerful visuals of students standing up to the police. But unlike many historic movements, this Gen Z protest had no silver-screen heroes. The students fought for themselves. Among the most striking moments from Mumbai, where 27-year-old model and actor Rhiya Ahir stood in front of a police van during a CJP protest. The image quickly went viral and has, in many ways, become the defining visual of the nationwide movement. Shared widely by netizens and

A Mumbai-based model, actor and entrepreneur, she is associated with the clothing brand 'Rhiyasat'

celebrities alike, the photograph shows Ahir standing directly in front of a police van near Shivaji Park after she reportedly noticed several detained demonstrators inside. Dressed in a grey hoodie, with her arms spread wide to block the van, Ahir's image is now trending across social media. Although videos from the scene show her standing firm, she later admitted that she was terrified throughout the confrontation. "When I con-

fronted them, I was shaking on the inside," she said. Yet, despite the fear, she refused to step aside. "I knew that what I was doing was right." Ahir already had a strong presence on 'Instagram', but the viral image has boosted her following. She now has 266K followers and has appeared in several music videos, the latest being 'Dilbara'. A Mumbai-based model, actor and entrepreneur, she is also reportedly associated with the clothing brand 'Rhiyasat'. On 'Instagram', she is also known as Rhiya Yadav. Responding to allegations that the incident was staged or paid for, Ahir clarified on 'Instagram' that she did what she believed was right at that moment. "Use your voice where it will make a difference. Jai Hindi," she wrote.

I've had experiences: Tom

Holland recalled promoting films he isn't proud of



LOS ANGELES: Tom Holland said it is easy to promote the films he is proud of and admits there were projects for which press tours weren't so easy. Holland, who recently featured in Christopher Nolan's 'The Odyssey' and is set for the release of his next 'Spider-Man' film, said his recent press tours were easy. "I'm absolutely loving it," he said on the 'Dish Podcast'. "When you're doing press for movies that you're really proud of, it's really easy. Because when they ask you questions about why people should go and watch this movie, you're not lying to anyone. You really think people should go see it," he added. He further shared, "I've had experiences before when people say, 'Why should you see this movie?' And in the back of your mind, you're like, 'You shouldn't, because it's s**t.'" 'The Odyssey' released on July 17 and also featured the actor in the role of Telemachus. His film 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day' will release on July 31. Directed by Destin Daniel Cretton, the film serves as the actor's fourth solo 'Spider-Man' film and his seventh overall appearance as Peter Parker/Spider-Man in the 'Marvel Cinematic Universe'. PTI

'When you're doing press for movies that you're really proud of, it's really easy,' he says

David Jonsson to portray the NEW BLACK PANTHER

Marvel Studios' used its Comic-Con International presentation on Saturday to announce David Jonsson as the new Black Panther - the son of Chadwick Boseman's T'Challa - and reveal that Ryan Gosling will be playing Ghost Rider, both in films set for release in 2028. Jonsson joined Oscar-winning 'Black Panther' franchise director Ryan Coogler on stage alongside Letitia Wright and Winston Duke, holding his hand to his chest and smiling broadly. Black Panther III is set for release on December 15, 2028. "Thank you to this family that I have the honour and the blessing to join. I don't want to say too much, because I want to let the screen do the talking," said the 32-year-old actor, known for roles in Industry, 'The Long Walk and Alien: Romulus'.



Chadwick Boseman died in 2020 and ever since 2022's 'Black Panther: Wakanda Forever' revealed that T'Challa had a son, fans have been playing a guessing game of who might take over the mantle, with Damson Idris and Wright in

He joined 'Black Panther' franchise director Ryan Coogler on stage

the mix. The original 2018 Black Panther became the first superhero film to earn a best picture Oscar nomination and made more than 1.3 billion dollars worldwide, while the sequel earned 850 million dollars. Ryan Gosling will re-team with director Shawn Levy on 'Ghost Rider'. "I'm having the greatest flashback vibes being here," said Levy in reference to his appearance at Hall H two years ago to promote 'Deadpool & Wolverine', which became a massive hit. "I'll never forget that night because it was also my real introduction to the greatest fans anywhere." AGENCIES

Prime Video sets stage at SDCC 2026 with teaser trailer

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video' announced that all eight episodes of the hotly anticipated new 'Original' series, 'Carrie', will premiere exclusively on 'Prime Video' on October 7. Kicking off a packed San Diego Comic-Con panel, 'Prime Video' debuted the official teaser trailer for 'Carrie', giving audiences a striking first look at Mike Flanagan's series adaptation - a fresh, contemporary reimagining of Stephen King's classic story. Chilling and emotionally grounded, the official teaser

signals the singular nature of this Carrie, hinting at new dimensions still to come. The panel concluded with showrunner and director Mike Flanagan revealing the premiere date and debuting new key art featuring a nod to the infamous prom, offering fans an early glimpse of both the adaptation's new perspective and the iconic moments that will unfold through newfound depth and tension across the series. Based on Stephen King's iconic debut novel, Carrie is a bold, timely and surprising reinvention of the classic com-



ing-of-age story, adapted as a television series for the first time by visionary showrunner Mike Flanagan. The series follows misfit high-schooler Carrie White (Summer H Howell), who has spent her life hidden away inside the walls of her home with her fiercely

pressure and casual cruelty of the social-media age and the awakening of mysterious telekinetic powers that rise alongside her adolescence. Told across eight propulsive episodes, the series expands King's cultural landmark, deepening its characters and tensions while following the small, everyday choices that build toward a single, shattering night in a gripping, deeply human story about kindness versus cruelty and whether we're witnessing the making of a hero, a monster or something far more complicated.

'Wanted him childlike, not caricaturish'

MUMBAI: Jaaved Jaaferi, who is basking in the success of his latest film 'Dhamaal 4', said bringing his popular character Manav to life required careful attention to everything from costumes and voice to body language. Directed by Indra Kumar, the 'Dhamaal' franchise follows a group of eccentric friends whose quest for hidden treasure leads to a series of comic misadventures. The fourth instalment, which released in theatres on June 10 and has earned over Rs 145 crore at the box office, Jaaferi alongside Ajay Devgn, Riteish Deshmukh, Arshad Warsi and Sanjay Mishra. Jaaferi reprises the role of Manav, simple-minded younger brother of Adi, played by Warsi. The two have been part of the franchise since the first part, which was released in 2007. The actor said sharing screen space with Warsi has always come naturally because of their decades-long friendship. "I've known him since he started his career as a dancer when he was 18. I've seen him grow. He used to come home and we've always shared a lot of love, affection and friendship. By the time we worked together, we already had that camaraderie," he told PTI in an interview. He still recalls the advice director Indra Kumar gave him after casting him as Manav in the first film. PTI

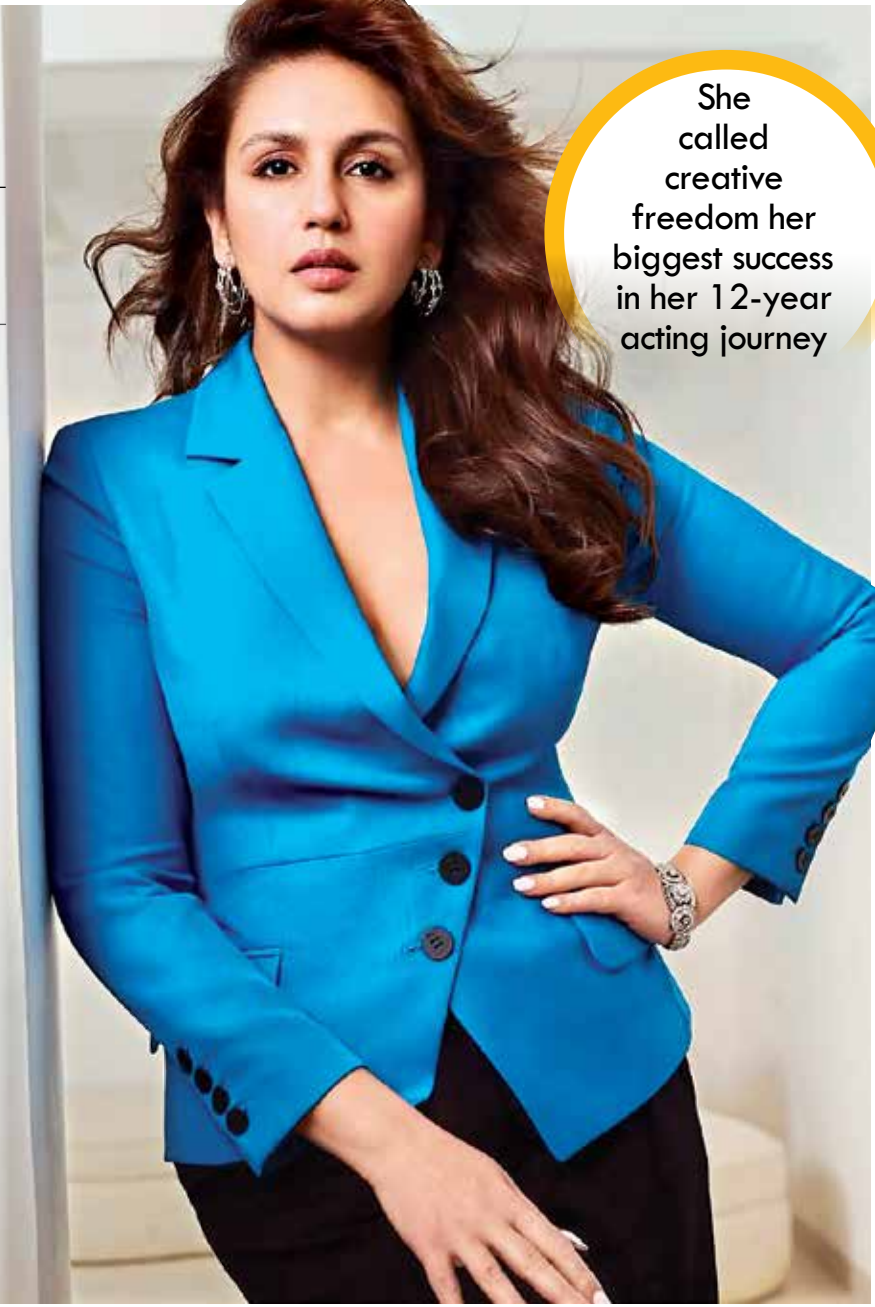


Jaaved Jaaferi talked about playing the character of Manav in the 'Dhamaal' franchise

'Toxic' star Huma Qureshi on refusing to be typecast

After spending over a decade in the film industry, Huma Qureshi believes she has finally reached a stage where she can shape her career on her own terms. The actress, who has completed 12 years in cinema, said she is now confident enough to bring her own creative touch to every project she takes up. This month, Huma has not only produced but also led the thriller 'Baby Do Die Do'. She will next be seen in Geethu Mohandas' action drama 'Toxic', starring Kanada superstar Yash. Calling the film a unique experience, she said, "It's a mad, different world." Looking back at her early years, Huma admitted her idea of success has evolved significantly. While fame and visibility once seemed like the ultimate goal, she now values creative independence above everything else. Speaking to 'Mid-Day', she shared, "I wanted people to know me then, but today, success is about choosing the work that I do or choosing the people that I get to work with. Being able to say no to parts that you don't align with and how you see yourself

as an artiste, that is success for me," she explained. Qureshi is equally vocal about resisting the industry's tendency to stereotype performers. "I resent being put in a box. As an actor, there's so much I can do, but I can't force somebody to give me an opportunity, even if I think I'd be really good at it. The opportunities that do come to me, I will try to ace them. It is fun and I take great pride in the fact that I can do a hot item song in the same year that I do an important piece about women's politics. I can age and de-age myself; I can do whatever because I'm an actor. I want to feel liberated from these shackles of other people's ideas and expectations. Image-wimage kuch nahi hota. It's what you want it to be," she asserted. Although Huma has built a reputation for choosing unconventional and performance-driven roles, there is one genre she still hopes to explore. She said she'd love to headline a romantic or mainstream commercial entertainer, even though such offers have largely eluded her. "If I do a commercial or romantic film, I will do it my way. I will not ape someone else's idea of it." AGENCIES



She called creative freedom her biggest success in her 12-year acting journey